From Manus to Cheir

The Frankenstein Clause and the Invention of a Chirurgical Humanism in Poor Things

A doctoral thesis in comparative literature, film studies, and the history of ideas, on Alasdair Gray's *Poor Things* (1992) and its adaptation by Yorgos Lanthimos and Tony McNamara (2023)

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… she, who in all probability was to become a thinking and reasoning animal, might refuse to comply with a compact made before her creation.

Mary Shelley, *Frankenstein* (1818), III.3

Set in TeX Gyre Pagella, a descendant of Hermann Zapf's Palatino, which took its name from a sixteenth-century writing master; and in Latin Modern Roman, a descendant of the Victorian "Modern" faces in which scientific and anatomical textbooks were set. The pages pass from monochrome into color as the argument proceeds, and each chapter plate joins two tones of one color along a stitched seam.

Contents

		Abstract	4
		Introduction: The Corpse Under the Bridge	6
	I	Genealogies of the Made Woman: Pygmalion, Olimpia, and the Frankenstein Clause	13
	II	The Anterior Compact: Unmündigkeit, Mundium, and the Sexual Contract	20
	III	The Experimental Subject: Sensation, Identity, Natality	28
	IV	Furious Jumping: The Erotics of Inquiry	35
	V	Heterotopias of Exchange: The Ship, the Balcony, the Brothel	42
	VI	The Mother's Body: Matricide, Revenance, and the Canon of Feminine Death	50
	VII	Gray's Anatomy: Metafiction, Nation, and the Scriptorial Hand	57
	VIII	Suture and Scar: The Cinematic Graft	64
	IX	Chirurgical Humanism: The Graft, the Garden, and the Goat	71
		Conclusion: In the Early Days of a Better Body	80
		Works Cited	84
		Filmography	88
		Keywords	89

Abstract

Alasdair Gray's *Poor Things* (1992) and its cinematic transfiguration by Yorgos Lanthimos and Tony McNamara (2023) have been read as a feminist *Frankenstein*, a picaresque *Bildungsroman*, a Menippean satire of Victorian moral economy, and, by a vocal strand of their reception, as a male-authored fantasy of female liberation that eroticizes the very infantilization it claims to critique. This thesis contends that each of these readings, however defensible, remains partial because none names the work's governing problem: the relation between a subject and the compacts that precede her. I call this problem the *anterior compact*, and its refusal the *Frankenstein Clause*, after the moment in Mary Shelley's novel when Victor, standing over the unfinished female creature he is about to destroy, fears that a being destined to reason "might refuse to comply with a compact made before her creation" (Shelley 1818, III.3).

Bella Baxter, a mind without a history lodged in a body with one, is the narrative instantiation of that clause. Her body arrives already bound: by coverture, by a prior marriage, by a pregnancy, and by the iconographic destiny that Victorian culture reserved for the drowned "fallen woman." Her mind consented to none of it. The work thereby separates what liberal and humanist discourse habitually fuses, the juridical person who is bound and the thinking subject who might consent, rendering the anterior compact visible as such and submitting it to dissection.

The argument proceeds on four registers. Philologically, it reconstructs the semantic history of tutelage over women, from Roman *manus* and *tutela mulierum*, through the Germanic *munt* or *mundium* that survives in Kant's *Vormund* and *Unmündigkeit*, to English coverture, and it observes that *emancipation* (*e manu capere*, release from the hand) reaches its terminus in this work not in escape from the hand but in the hand's appropriation as *cheirourgia*: hand-work, surgery. Philosophically, it situates the work within a lineage running from Pico della Mirandola, Locke, Condillac, Rousseau, Wollstonecraft, William Godwin, Kant, and Mill, through Fourier, Marx, and Engels, to Beauvoir, Arendt, Foucault, Irigaray, Pateman, Lorde, and Haraway. Historically, it reads the narrative against Victorian clitoridectomy, the

Contagious Diseases Acts, the Married Women's Property Acts, anti-vivisection feminism, and the regulated brothel. Formally, it treats the novel's metafictional apparatus and the film's chromatic, optical, and scenographic regimes as operations rather than ornaments.

From this convergence the thesis derives an original proposition: that *Poor Things* articulates a *chirurgical humanism*. This is an account of the human as graft, rather than as organism (Humboldt, Mill) or machine (La Mettrie), whose dignity resides neither in an essence, nor in a rational will, nor in a social construction, but in the cultivated capacity of the operative hand to cut, join, and reassemble the given. That capacity is held under a discipline of the visible scar, which refuses the seamless suture of both classical cinema and liberal ideology. The thesis further argues that novel and film form the two halves of a *bimanual* feminism. Gray's text culminates in a letter, in which Victoria McCandless rewrites the male narrative that made her; Lanthimos and McNamara's film culminates in a goat, in which Bella rewrites the male body that claimed her. The scriptorial hand refutes the fantasy from outside; the surgical hand refutes power from within it.

The film's terminal tableau, in which Bella, having replaced General Blessington's brain with a goat's while he lay unconscious, without his consent or any trial, keeps his living body grazing in a garden of made kin, is read finally as a dialectical image in Walter Benjamin's sense, one in which emancipation and the inherited violence of the scalpel are legible in a single frame. The work thereby stages, without resolving, Audre Lorde's question whether the master's tools can dismantle the master's house, and Wollstonecraft's older demand that women seek power not over men but over themselves. Its achievement is to make that irresolution operative: it does not conceal its scars.

Introduction

The Corpse Under the Bridge

I *The terminus refused*

THE FILM OPENS WHERE the nineteenth century habitually closed its accounts with women. A woman stands on the parapet of a London bridge and lets herself fall into the Thames. The image is not innocent; it belongs to one of the densest iconographies of Victorian culture, that of the drowned "fallen woman." Thomas Hood's "The Bridge of Sighs" (1844), with its "One more Unfortunate, / Weary of breath," supplied the period's elegiac formula for the suicide of the seduced. G. F. Watts's *Found Drowned* (c. 1848–50) laid her corpse beneath the arches of Waterloo Bridge; the third panel of Augustus Egg's *Past and Present* (1858) sheltered the outcast wife under the Adelphi arches; Dickens's Martha Endell stares at the river in *David Copperfield* (1850) as at her only remaining destination; Millais's *Ophelia* (1851–52) floated the whole tradition in Pre-Raphaelite light. In each case the river functions as the narrative's solvent. It dissolves the transgressive woman into an aesthetic object and returns the moral economy to equilibrium.

Edgar Allan Poe had stated the underlying doctrine with algebraic candor: the death of a beautiful woman is "unquestionably, the most poetical topic in the world" (Poe 1846). Elisabeth Bronfen's *Over Her Dead Body*, published in 1992, the same year as Alasdair Gray's novel, demonstrated that Poe's dictum was not an idiosyncratic taste but a structural requirement of Western representation, which repeatedly stabilizes its codes of gender, death, and art by passing through the corpse of a woman (Bronfen 1992). *Poor Things* begins at precisely the point where that aesthetic reaches its terminus, and it refuses the terminus. The corpse is found, as Watts's was, but it is not composed into an elegy. It is opened, rewired, and made to live. The "most poetical topic in the world" is converted into the precondition of a biography. This conversion, I shall argue, is not a macabre premise from which a comedy of manners then departs. It is the work's thesis in compressed form.

II *Two bodies of one work*

The material under study exists in two bodies. The first is Gray's *Poor Things: Episodes from the Early Life of Archibald McCandless M.D., Scottish Public Health Officer* (1992), presented as a Frankenstein-like assemblage of documents: an introduction by a fictional editor named Alasdair Gray, McCandless's privately printed memoir of 1909, a letter by Victoria McCandless repudiating that memoir, and a sheaf of "Notes Critical and Historical," all illustrated with portraits that the text attributes to the etcher

William Strang but which Gray drew himself, interleaved with punning fragments from *Gray's Anatomy* (Procter 2008; Gray 1992). The second is the film directed by Yorgos Lanthimos from a screenplay by Tony McNamara, produced with Emma Stone among its producers, which premiered at the 80th Venice International Film Festival on 1 September 2023, won the Golden Lion, and received four Academy Awards, including Best Actress for Stone.

The film excises the novel's documentary apparatus, relocates the action from Glasgow to a fantasized London, abolishes the epistemic hesitation between the fantastic and the natural that Gray sustains to his last page, and supplies an ending without precedent in the book. These changes are often discussed as losses or liberties. I treat them instead as operations performed upon a shared body of material, in the spirit of André Bazin's defense of an "impure cinema," Robert Stam's dialogics of adaptation, and Linda Hutcheon's account of adaptation as "repetition without replication" (Bazin 1952; Stam 2000; Hutcheon 2006). Novel and film are not original and copy. They are, in a sense that the body of this thesis will make exact, two hands working on one body.

III *The critical field*

The scholarship on Gray's novel has privileged three lines of inquiry. The first reads it as historiographic metafiction in Linda Hutcheon's sense, a text that installs and subverts the authority of the historical document (Hutcheon 1988; Bernstein 1999). The second reads it as national allegory, situating Bella within the problem of Scottish selfhood after 1707 and within Gray's own polemical politics, which in 1992 also produced the pamphlet *Why Scots Should Rule Scotland* (Kaczvinsky 2001; Craig 1999; Procter 2008). The third, attentive to the grotesque, reads Bella and her maker as figures of social resistance (March 2002). A quieter strand has asked how a male author whose earlier fictions, notably *1982, Janine* (1984) and *Something Leather* (1990), had thematized male sexual fantasy, could write a feminist fable without merely restaging that fantasy in better clothes.

The film's reception has reproduced that last question at the scale of mass culture. Alongside widespread acclaim, a substantial body of journalistic and online criticism raised four objections: that a male-directed and male-written film eroticizes a woman under the alibi of liberating her; that it shows an adult man, Wedderburn, initiating sex with a woman whom the film presents as having a child's understanding, and so depicts, and risks eroticizing, the sexual exploitation of a person who may lack the capacity to consent, a framing some commentators called pedophilic; that

the Alexandria sequence instrumentalizes the colonized poor as a backdrop for a white heroine's moral education; and that the Paris sequence romanticizes prostitution. Stone's own defense, that Bella's freedom from shame was the condition of the character and that the camera's discretion would have been a form of dishonesty, has been widely reported. This thesis neither dismisses these objections nor rehearses the defense. It reframes the objections as internal to the work's own problematic, and it argues that the work anticipates them more completely than its critics or its defenders have allowed, without wholly answering them.

IV *The governing problem: the anterior compact*

Every subject is born into compacts it did not make: a language, a kinship system, a legal status, a property regime, and the gendered destinies that narrative forms distribute in advance. Classical social contract theory, from Hobbes through Locke to Rousseau, imagined consent as the foundation of legitimate authority. Feminist critics from Mary Astell onward objected that women entered that order bound by a prior agreement they never signed; Astell's question of 1706, how it could be that all men are born free while all women are born slaves, remains the shortest statement of the case (Astell 1706). Carole Pateman's *The Sexual Contract* (1988) gave it its modern form: the social contract presupposes a sexual contract that secures men's access to women's bodies, and civil freedom is accordingly a patriarchal inheritance.

I name this structure the *anterior compact*. Its most precise literary formulation appears, not in a treatise, but in a moment of panic. In the third volume of *Frankenstein*, Victor, having agreed to fabricate a mate for his creature, stops work and reasons that the female being, who "in all probability was to become a thinking and reasoning animal," might "refuse to comply with a compact made before her creation"; she might even turn from her intended partner "to the superior beauty of man" and "quit him" (Shelley 1818, III.3). He then tears her half-finished body apart. I call the possibility that Victor dreads the *Frankenstein Clause*. It has two parts: the capacity of a subject who attains reason to repudiate obligations contracted in her name before she could consent, and the dread that this capacity inspires in those whose authority rests upon such obligations.

Poor Things is the narrative realization of that clause, and Bella's constitution explains why. She is a mind without a history lodged in a body with one. Her body is already a wife, already a mother-to-be, already a person under coverture, already the protagonist of a Victorian suicide. Her mind is a newborn's. The work thereby separates what liberal and

humanist discourse normally fuses, the juridical person who is bound and the thinking subject who might consent, and in separating them it makes the anterior compact visible *as such*. When General Blessington arrives at Bella's wedding to reclaim his wife, he is presenting, with perfect literalness, a compact made before her creation. Bella's refusal of it is the Frankenstein Clause executed.

V *The hand*

The second governing problem is lexical, and it is older than the novel. The European vocabulary of women's subordination is a vocabulary of the hand. In Roman law, a wife who married *cum manu* passed into her husband's *manus*, his hand; adult women outside marriage were kept under *tutela mulierum*, perpetual guardianship; and a son was released from paternal power by *emancipatio*, a ritual of sale whose name derives from *manus* and *capere*, to take by the hand. In Germanic law, guardianship over women was the *munt* or *mundium*, a word whose semantic field joins "hand" and "protection" and which survives in Kant's *Vormund* (guardian) and *Unmündigkeit* (immaturity, tutelage). In English common law, Blackstone's doctrine of coverture held that by marriage "the very being or legal existence of the woman is suspended," incorporated into that of a husband "under whose wing, protection, and *cover*, she performs every thing" (Blackstone 1765, I.15).

Poor Things passes through every station of this vocabulary. Bella is handled by a possessive hand (Wedderburn's, then Blessington's), by a tutelary hand (Godwin's, Max's, the housekeeper's), and finally by her own. The work's terminal figure is a woman with a scalpel, and surgery, *cheirourgia*, is etymologically nothing other than hand-work. The thesis therefore advances a philological proposition: in this work, emancipation, the release from the hand, completes itself not as escape from the hand but as the hand's appropriation. To these three hands Gray's novel adds a fourth, which the film removes: the scriptorial hand of Victoria McCandless, who answers the man's narrative of her making with a letter of her own.

VI *Chirurgical humanism: a provisional definition*

From the convergence of these two problems the thesis derives its central proposition, that *Poor Things* articulates what I call a *chirurgical humanism*. It is defined, provisionally, by what it is not. It is not the essentialist humanism of natural law, which grounds dignity in a given human nature, since Bella has no given nature. It is not the voluntarist humanism of Kant,

which grounds dignity in the rational will's self-legislation, since Bella's will is visibly the product of embodied acceleration rather than resolve. It is not the organicist humanism of Wilhelm von Humboldt and John Stuart Mill, for whom the human is a plant to be cultivated toward its own fullness, since Bella is not grown but grafted. It is not the constructionist position that runs from Beauvoir to Butler, since Bella is constructed, quite literally, and the question is what she does with her construction. Nor is it the antihumanism announced by Foucault's image of man as a figure drawn in sand at the edge of the sea, or the posthumanism of Rosi Braidotti and Donna Haraway, though it borrows from both.

Chirurgical humanism conceives the human as a graft: a being composed of heterogeneous materials joined by an operative hand, whose identity is the scar between them. It locates dignity in the cultivated capacity to cut, join, and reassemble the given, including one's own given. It holds that capacity under a discipline of visibility, refusing the seamless suture by which classical cinema conceals its cuts and liberal ideology conceals its compacts. And it confronts, rather than evades, the objection that Audre Lorde formulated in the title of her 1979 address, that the master's tools will never dismantle the master's house. The scalpel that Bella takes up was her maker's, and his father's before him.

VII *Method, texts, and conventions*

The method is comparative and multi-registered: close reading of novel and film; philology of the legal and medical lexicon; intellectual history from Renaissance humanism to contemporary feminist and posthumanist theory; social history of Victorian sexuality, medicine, and marriage law; and formal analysis of cinematography, scenography, and performance. Gray's novel is cited from the first edition (Gray 1992). The film is cited as *Poor Things* (Lanthimos 2023). Film dialogue is paraphrased, with very brief quotation where a coinage is itself the object of analysis. Translations from Latin, Greek, German, and French are my own unless otherwise noted. Works in the public domain are cited by book, chapter, or line; modern scholarship by author and date. Factual details of the novel's genesis and apparatus, and of the film's production, were checked against the archival and online sources listed at the end of the Works Cited.

VIII *Structure of the argument*

Chapter One reconstructs the genealogy of the made woman, from Ovid's Pygmalion and Rousseau's Galathée through Hoffmann's Olimpia to the female creature Victor destroys, and reads Gray's naming of Godwin

Bysshe Baxter as the key to a buried family romance of English radicalism. Chapter Two anatomizes the anterior compact through Kant's essay on enlightenment, the law of tutelage, Pateman's sexual contract, and Mill's liberal developmentalism, and confronts the problem of consent. Chapter Three examines Bella as an experimental subject in the traditions of Locke, Condillac, Itard, Rousseau, Pico, Sartre, and Arendt. Chapter Four reads her sexuality through Eden, Foucault, Victorian clitoridectomy, Irigaray, Cixous, Lorde, Bakhtin, and Bergson. Chapter Five follows her through three heterotopias in Foucault's sense, the ship, the Alexandrian balcony, and the Paris brothel, where she becomes Marx's speaking commodity. Chapter Six returns to the mother's body, the drowned-heroine archive, and the inverted *Oresteia*. Chapter Seven turns to Gray's metafictional apparatus, its Scottish allegory, and the scriptorial hand. Chapter Eight analyzes the film's form as an aesthetics of the visible scar. Chapter Nine assembles the theory of chirurgical humanism around the graft, the garden, and the goat. The Conclusion assesses its reach and its limits.

I

Genealogies of the Made Woman

Pygmalion, Olimpia, and the Frankenstein Clause

THE MADE WOMAN IS among the oldest figures in the Western archive, and nearly every version of her is a fantasy of male authorship that she is not permitted to answer. *Poor Things* inherits this genealogy and inverts its decisive terms. This chapter reconstructs four stations of the genealogy (the statue, the automaton, the destroyed female creature, and the daughter named after her mother) and argues that Gray's naming of his creator, Godwin Bysshe Baxter, opens a fifth: a buried family romance of English radicalism in which the drowned mother, the philosopher-father, and the daughter born of her mother's death are condensed into a single body.

1.1 *Ivory and stone: the Pygmalion inversion*

Ovid's Pygmalion episode is usually read as a fable of art's power to quicken matter. Its frame is less often remembered. Pygmalion turns from living women because he has seen the Propoetides, the women of Amathus who denied the divinity of Venus, were punished by becoming the first to sell their bodies, and, as their shame drained away, hardened into stone (*Metamorphoses* X.238–242). Offended by "the vices nature gave the female mind," he lives unmarried and carves a woman from ivory (X.243–246). The myth of the made woman therefore begins as a reaction formation against the prostitute. The ivory maiden is the anti-Propoetid: white where they are hardened, silent where they were shameless, wholly the maker's where they belonged to anyone who paid.

Poor Things reverses the sequence. Its made woman is fabricated by a man, desired as an ideal, and then walks of her own accord into the trade of the Propoetides, entering a Paris brothel in order to fund herself and her studies. She does not turn to stone. The petrification that Ovid presents as the natural consequence of a woman's commerce in her own body is precisely what the work declines to stage. This is the first of the many inversions by which *Poor Things* reopens the archive of the made woman: Pygmalion's statue becomes one of the Propoetides, and survives.

1.2 *"Encore moi": Galathée and the self located in the maker*

Ovid's statue has no name and no line of dialogue. The name Galatea attaches to her durably only in the eighteenth century, most influentially through Rousseau's *Pygmalion*, a *scène lyrique* written in 1762 and performed in Lyon in 1770. Rousseau gives the animated statue three utterances, and they constitute a complete theory of feminine subjectivity. Touching herself, Galathée says "Moi." Touching another block of marble, she says "Ce n'est plus moi." Touching Pygmalion, she says "Ah! encore

moi": ah, me again. Her selfhood is discovered in her body, distinguished from inert matter, and then relocated in her maker. The circuit of recognition closes on the man.

It is no accident that the same author, in the same year, published *Émile*, whose fifth book prescribes for Sophie an education that is "relative to men" in its entirety (Rousseau 1762, V). Galathée is Sophie in marble. *Poor Things* stages Galathée's first utterance and refuses her third. Bella's earliest discovery of herself is masturbation: she finds pleasure in her own body with an apple, at the table, and reports it with comic matter-of-factness, and her selfhood never relocates in Godwin. She loves him, she calls him "God," and she leaves him. The circuit of recognition does not close on the maker.

1.3 *Automata: Olimpia, Hadaly, and the dance*

The nineteenth century mechanized Galatea. In E. T. A. Hoffmann's "Der Sandmann" (1816), Nathanael falls in love with Olimpia, the automaton "daughter" of Professor Spalanzani. Hoffmann named the professor after Lazzaro Spallanzani, the naturalist credited with the first successful artificial insemination of a mammal. The made woman's father thus bears the name of artificial reproduction itself. Olimpia's vocabulary consists of the sigh "Ach!"; Nathanael hears in it a depth of understanding no living woman has offered him. Freud's "Das Unheimliche" (1919), revising Ernst Jentsch's account of the uncanny as intellectual uncertainty about whether a figure is alive, made the tale canonical as an allegory of male castration anxiety. In both readings the uncanny is the man's crisis; Olimpia has no interior to have a crisis in.

Villiers de l'Isle-Adam's *L'Ève future* (1886) completed the logic: a fictional Edison manufactures Hadaly, an android replica of a beautiful but vulgar singer, for a lord who loves the singer's body and despises her mind. Léo Delibes's ballet *Coppélia* (1870) had already supplied the comic counter-move, in which a living woman impersonates the doll to expose the folly of the men who prefer it. Shaw's *Pygmalion* (1913) transposed the whole problem into class and phonetics, and Shaw spent years insisting, against audiences and adapters, that Eliza does not marry Higgins.

Bella's body begins in this tradition. Stone's early performance, with its stiff, jointed gait, its percussive gestures, and its oddly placed weight, cites the automaton directly. The film's most celebrated sequence, Bella's dance in a Lisbon ballroom, cites Olympia's mechanical dance in Offenbach's *Les contes d'Hoffmann*, which Powell and Pressburger filmed in 1951 with Moira Shearer as the doll. But the citation is turned. Olympia's dance is driven by a mechanism that her partners wind and that runs down. Bella's

dance is driven by a mechanism that no partner can wind. Wedderburn attempts to lead her, to correct her, to fold her back into the couple form, and she repeatedly breaks away into movements that have no partner at all. Where Olimpia's dance displays the man's power to animate, Bella's displays the failure of that power.

1.4 *The female creature: Victor's nightmare as premise*

The decisive ancestor is the being Victor Frankenstein never finishes. Having promised his creature a mate "of the same species," Victor travels to Scotland, establishes a laboratory in a hut on one of the remotest of the Orkney islands, and works until he is overtaken by the reasoning quoted in the Introduction: that she might become a thinking being, that she might repudiate the compact made before her creation, that she might prefer "the superior beauty of man," and that the pair might propagate "a race of devils" (Shelley 1818, III.3). He destroys her body while the creature watches through the window. It is worth pausing on the geography. Mary Shelley's female creature is made, and unmade, in Scotland. Gray, writing from Glasgow, resumes in Scotland the experiment that Victor aborted there, and completes it.

The feminist criticism of *Frankenstein* supplies the vocabulary for what that completion means. Ellen Moers read the novel as a "birth myth," shaped by Mary Shelley's experience of pregnancy and of an infant's death (Moers 1976). Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar read the creature as a "monstrous Eve," the female self as Milton's tradition imagined it, deformed and abandoned (Gilbert and Gubar 1979). Anne Mellor read Victor's project as the male usurpation of female reproduction, and drew attention to his dream on the night of the creation: he kisses Elizabeth, her lips turn "livid with the hue of death," and he finds himself holding "the corpse of my dead mother" (Shelley 1818, I.4; Mellor 1988). Barbara Johnson read the novel as an autobiography of female monstrosity, in which a woman's self-representation is necessarily the representation of a monster (Johnson 1982).

Poor Things converts each of these readings into plot. It is a birth myth in which birth and death occur in a single body. Its heroine is Eve, but an Eve whose making is not followed by a fall. Its creator does usurp female reproduction, quite literally, by bringing to term a pregnancy whose bearer had chosen to end it. And Victor's nightmare becomes the premise: the beloved whom Max and Wedderburn desire *is* the reanimated corpse of a mother. What Victor experienced as horror, and what Mellor diagnosed as the unconscious of male creation, is here the material condition of a heroine's life.

Yet the work's attitude toward its Victor differs from Shelley's. Godwin Baxter does not abandon his creature. He feeds her, teaches her, records her, and, when she demands to leave with Wedderburn, permits it after a struggle with himself. He is a corrected Frankenstein, a maker who accepts in advance that the made being will refuse the compact. This is the work's utopian wager, and it is also, as later chapters will show, the source of its most persistent ambiguity, since the acceptance is itself an act of sovereign permission.

1.5 *Godwin Bysshe Baxter: the family romance of English radicalism*

Gray's creator is named Godwin Bysshe Baxter: an allusion, as has been noted, to both Mary Shelley's father and her husband (Procter 2008; McIlroy 2024). The allusion is usually treated as a learned wink. I propose that it is the key to a structural allegory that organizes the novel and survives, transformed, in the film. Consider the historical sequence.

In October 1795, Mary Wollstonecraft, abandoned by Gilbert Imlay, walked through the rain until her clothes were heavy, threw herself from Putney Bridge into the Thames, and was pulled from the water by watermen. Two years later she married William Godwin, the philosopher who had argued in *Political Justice* (1793) that marriage was "the worst of all properties" and who married her nonetheless because she was pregnant. She died of puerperal fever eleven days after the birth of their daughter Mary in September 1797. Within months Godwin published his *Memoirs of the Author of A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1798), a loving and candid life that disclosed her liaisons, her illegitimate first daughter, and her attempts at suicide. The book destroyed her reputation for a century; Robert Southey accused Godwin of stripping his dead wife naked. The daughter, according to a durable family tradition, learned her letters by tracing her mother's name on the gravestone in St Pancras churchyard, and it was beside that grave that she met Percy Bysshe Shelley. In July 1814, at sixteen, she eloped with him, a married man and a theorist of free love, to the Continent. Her father, the old enemy of marriage, refused to see her.

The correspondences with *Poor Things* are exact enough to be structural. A woman leaps from a London bridge into the Thames in despair at a man. A philosopher named Godwin retrieves her: the historical Godwin textually, in a memoir that reanimates her life while exposing her body to public view; Gray's and Lanthimos's Godwin surgically, in an operation that reanimates her body while installing a new life in it. A daughter is born of the mother's death and grows up in the father's house as the

mother's continuation. A radical seducer carries the daughter off to the Continent, and the father's principles prove unequal to the event. Even the textual forms correspond. Mary's first book was a travel narrative of that elopement, *History of a Six Weeks' Tour* (1817); Bella's long letter from her travels, in Gray's novel, is her first sustained text. Mary's second book was *Frankenstein*. Victoria's letter, in Gray's novel, is the daughter's counter-text to the man's Gothic romance of her making.

Poor Things is therefore, at its foundation, a fantasia on the founding family of English radical feminism, in which Wollstonecraft and Mary Shelley, mother and daughter, occupy one body. The novel and the film distribute the male roles differently, and the difference is instructive. Gray condenses father and lover into a single name: Godwin Bysshe Baxter is Mary's father and Mary's husband at once, and in the novel's main narrative he is in love with Bella. The film distributes that compound across a cast: Godwin is the father; Wedderburn, the libertine of the elopement, is a debased Bysshe whose free-love rhetoric collapses into proprietary rage; Max is the husband; and Blessington is the prior husband who is also, by the film's tacit logic, the father of the child whose brain Bella carries. Gray's single name contains the whole male cast of the film.

One further layer deserves record. Willem Dafoe has said that he built his Godwin from videos of Gray himself, finding much of the author in the character (McIlroy 2024). The film's creator-figure is thus modeled on the novel's creator. The allegory of authorship that *Frankenstein* has always carried, Victor as novelist and the creature as the novel, is here embodied in a casting decision: the man who made Bella on screen wears the face and voice of the man who made her on the page.

1.6 *Morella and the name*

The last station of the genealogy is the most precise and the least remarked. In Poe's "Morella" (1835), the narrator's wife, a student of mystical philosophy who discourses on personal identity and cites Locke's definition of it, dies in giving birth to a daughter. The child grows, in Poe's words, "strangely in stature and intellect," acquiring with uncanny speed the mind and features of her mother. The father withholds a name from her for ten years. When at last he names her at the baptismal font, the name he speaks is "Morella." The girl answers that she is here, and dies; when he carries her to the family tomb, he finds no trace of the first Morella.

Here is the entire premise of *Poor Things* in miniature: a mother who dies in childbirth, a daughter of preternaturally accelerated development who is her mother's double, and a philosophical problem of personal identity explicitly referred to Locke. Poe's tale resolves the problem by

naming, and the name kills. To be called by the mother's name is to become the mother and therefore to die her death. *Poor Things* reverses the resolution. Godwin names his creature Bella, not Victoria. When Blessington arrives to reclaim her and insists upon the name Victoria, the work stages Poe's baptism as a choice, and Bella refuses it. She inhabits her mother's body without accepting her mother's name, and she survives.

The name she does bear is not neutral. "Bella" is the Italian for beautiful; it inscribes into the heroine's identity the very aesthetic that Poe's dictum required to be killed. Gray, moreover, drew an illustration titled "Bella Caledonia," binding the name to Scotland itself (McIlroy 2024). And the heroine renames her maker in turn. Genesis gives Adam the power to name the animals and then the woman (Genesis 2:19–23). Bella reverses the order of nomination: the creature names the creator, and the name she gives him is a truncation. "God" is what remains of Godwin when the second syllable is cut away. Her first act of authority over him is, in the most literal sense, a small surgery on his name.

1.7 *Conclusion: the made woman who unmakes her genre*

Across these stations a single pattern emerges. The made woman of the Western tradition is defined by three features: she is fabricated against the figure of the sexual woman, she locates her selfhood in her maker, and her autonomy is either impossible (Olimpia, Hadaly), fatal (Morella), or preemptively destroyed (Victor's female creature). *Poor Things* retains the first feature and inverts it, cancels the second, and refutes the third. Its heroine is the female creature whom Victor dreaded, completed in the country where he destroyed her, raised by a corrected Victor, bearing a name that refuses her mother's, and carrying in her body the whole drowned genealogy of English radical feminism. The next chapter turns from her ancestry to the compacts that awaited her at birth.

II

The Anterior Compact

Unmündigkeit, Mundium, and the Sexual Contract

BELLA'S BODY COMES TO her already contracted. This chapter reconstructs the legal and philosophical architecture of that condition, which I have called the anterior compact, through four sources: Kant's essay on enlightenment, whose central metaphors the film literalizes; the law of the hand, from Roman *manus* through the Germanic *mundium* to English coverture; the contract theory of marriage and its feminist critique from Astell to Pateman; and Mill's liberal developmentalism, which tied the capacity for freedom to a threshold of maturity that was also a racial and civilizational threshold. It closes by confronting the most serious objection to the film, which concerns consent.

2.1 *Kant's guardians and the literal go-cart*

Kant's "Beantwortung der Frage: Was ist Aufklärung?" (1784) opens with a definition: enlightenment is humanity's exit from its self-incurred immaturity (*selbstverschuldete Unmündigkeit*), immaturity being the inability to use one's understanding without the guidance of another. The cause is not a lack of understanding but a lack of resolve and courage, and the motto is Horace's *sapere aude*. Kant then turns to the guardians (*Vormünder*) who "have so kindly taken upon themselves" the supervision of others, and adds a parenthesis that the history of philosophy has been slow to read: that by far the greater part of humanity, "among them the entire fair sex," regards the step to maturity as not merely arduous but highly dangerous is the work of those very guardians. Having first made their domestic animals (*Hausvieh*) stupid, the guardians take care that these placid creatures dare not take a single step outside the go-cart (*Gängelwagen*) in which they are confined, and show them the danger of walking alone. The danger, Kant adds, is not great: after a few falls, they would learn to walk.

Poor Things stages this paragraph almost line by line. Godwin's house is populated with domestic animals made strange, the chimeric goose-dogs and pig-hens that wander its rooms. Its central figure must learn to walk, and does so with a falling, jointed gait. Her guardians, Godwin, Max, and the housekeeper Mrs Prim, keep her within the house, explaining the dangers of the world outside. The marriage contract that Godwin commissions makes her confinement a condition of her betrothal. And after a few falls she does learn to walk, out the door and onto a ship.

But the film corrects Kant at the point where his parenthesis falters. Bella's immaturity is not self-incurred. It was produced surgically, by the guardian himself, who chose to install an infant's brain in an adult body. The work thereby renders explicit what Kant's parenthesis concedes and his definition conceals: that the *Unmündigkeit* of the "fair sex" was never

selbstverschuldet, but manufactured by the guardians who then presented the step out of it as perilous. Nor does Bella exit immaturity through Kant's mechanism of resolve and courage. She grows out of it through appetite. The philology of Kant's motto is apt here. Latin *sapere* means to be wise only by extension; its root sense is to taste, to have a flavor, whence *sapor*, savor. Bella's enlightenment is literally a daring to taste: custard tarts in Lisbon, the body's pleasures, books, the misery of Alexandria. *Sapere aude*, in this work, is an injunction addressed to the tongue before it is addressed to the understanding.

2.2 *The law of the hand*

Kant's *Vormund* and *Unmündigkeit* descend from the Germanic legal concept of *munt*, Latinized as *mundium*: the protective power that a father, husband, or kinsman held over those who could not represent themselves at law, preeminently women. Old English *mund* joined the senses of hand and protection in a single word. The Lombard Edict of Rothari (643) forbade a free woman to live in her own power, in what the text calls *selbmundia*, self-guardianship; she was always to be under some man's *mundium*, transferred from father to husband at marriage, and the transfer had its price. The concept that the law denied women, *selbmundia*, is the precise name for what Bella achieves.

Rome had organized the same structure around *manus*. A wife married *cum manu* passed into her husband's hand, sometimes by *coemptio*, a ritual sale. Women outside such marriages were kept under *tutela mulierum*, perpetual guardianship, whose traditional justification Gaius records as the "lightness of mind" of women (*animi levitas*), before conceding that the reason seemed to him more specious than true (Gaius, *Institutes* I.144, I.190). And a son was released from his father's power by *emancipatio*, a procedure grounded in a clause of the Twelve Tables providing that a father who sold his son three times should lose his power over him. Emancipation was, in its origin, a juridical fiction of triple sale: freedom produced by passing the person through commodification until the owner's title was exhausted.

The film re-enacts this fiction with uncanny precision. Bella is transferred three times before she is free. First, by the marriage contract that Godwin commissions to pass her guardianship to Max. Second, by Wedderburn, who, when he can no longer control her in Lisbon, abducts her, smuggling her aboard a ship in a steamer trunk as if she were luggage: the woman reduced to chattel in the most literal form. Third, by herself, in the Paris brothel, where she sells her body on her own account. After the

third sale, she returns to London able to refuse the claim of the man who held her original title.

English common law gave the same structure its Victorian form. Blackstone's coverture suspended the wife's legal existence and incorporated it into her husband's (Blackstone 1765, I.15). Until the Married Women's Property Acts of 1870 and 1882, a married woman's property passed to her husband; until the Matrimonial Causes Act of 1857, divorce required a private Act of Parliament, and even after it a wife had to prove adultery aggravated by cruelty, desertion, incest, or bigamy, where a husband needed only to prove adultery. Caroline Norton's campaigns of the 1830s to 1850s, waged after her husband, George Norton, had denied her access to her children and claimed her earnings, made the case notorious. Frances Power Cobbe's "Wife-Torture in England" (1878) contributed to the Matrimonial Causes Act of that year, which allowed magistrates to grant separation to wives whose husbands had been convicted of aggravated assault. Within this regime, a woman married to a man like Blessington had no exit that the law would honor. Victoria's leap from the bridge, which the film presents as her escape from an abusive husband, is the only door coverture left open. The film's Blessington household, with its terrorized servants and its master's pistol, is the domestic sovereignty that coverture guaranteed, rendered visible.

2.3 *The sexual contract and the traffic in women*

The philosophical justification of that sovereignty was contractual. Locke, having dismantled patriarchal absolutism in the political sphere, conceded that in conjugal society the final determination "naturally falls to the man's share, as the abler and the stronger" (Locke 1689, *Second Treatise* §82). Mary Astell's riposte, quoted in the Introduction, exposed the contradiction: a theory that founded political authority on the natural freedom of individuals reinstated natural subordination at the threshold of the household (Astell 1706). The Enlightenment's own feminist critics pressed the point in the language of rights: Condorcet argued for the admission of women to citizenship (1790); Olympe de Gouges declared that woman is born free and remains equal to man in rights, and that if a woman has the right to mount the scaffold she must equally have the right to mount the tribune (de Gouges 1791, arts. 1, 10); Wollstonecraft demanded for women an education of reason rather than of ornament (Wollstonecraft 1792). De Gouges mounted the scaffold in 1793.

Carole Pateman's *The Sexual Contract* (1988) systematized the critique. The "original contract" of political theory, she argued, is a sexual as well as a social pact, establishing men's orderly access to women's bodies; civil

freedom is accordingly a masculine attribute, and the marriage contract, the employment contract, and the prostitution contract are variations on a single structure in which command over a body is exchanged under the appearance of free agreement. Gayle Rubin's "The Traffic in Women" (1975), reworking Lévi-Strauss's theory of kinship as the exchange of women between men, had already shown that women in such systems are conduits of relations among men rather than parties to them. Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick's *Between Men* (1985) added that the erotic triangle in which two men contend for a woman is often, at bottom, a bond between the men.

Poor Things dramatizes all three theses. Its plot is set in motion by a contract to which the woman is not a party. Godwin commissions a lawyer to draft the terms of Bella's marriage to Max, and the lawyer, Wedderburn, is drawn to her precisely because the contract is so elaborate; he wants to know what could require such protection. His desire is born of the contract, in the strict Girardian sense of mimetic desire: he desires what another has been promised, and he desires it because it has been promised (Girard 1961). The lawyer who drafts the sexual contract is its first violator, and the contract produces the very desire it was designed to regulate. Rubin's conduit is visible in the film's most precise early detail: in Lisbon, a fellow guest at the hotel addresses Bella as Victoria Blessington, and the anterior compact surfaces as a misrecognition, a stranger's ghost-name. And Sedgwick's homosocial bond is the engine of the final act. When Wedderburn returns from the asylum to the wedding, he brings Blessington with him. The jilted lover and the cheated husband, rivals in principle, form an alliance in fact, pooling their claims against the woman who escaped both. The scene is a small anatomy of the sexual contract: when one man's title fails, he seeks out the man whose title is older.

2.4 *Mill's hothouse and the waiting room of history*

John Stuart Mill's *The Subjection of Women* (1869) posed the epistemological question that *Poor Things* answers with a thought experiment. What is now called the nature of women, Mill wrote, is "an eminently artificial thing," the result of forced repression in some directions and unnatural stimulation in others; some of women's capacities had been subjected to a "hot-house and stove cultivation" for the benefit of their masters, while others had been left out in the cold (Mill 1869, ch. 1). It followed that no one could know what women's nature was, since no woman had developed outside the hothouse. Bella is the counterfactual Mill could not produce: an adult woman whose development begins outside the history that formed every other woman.

The work does not, however, accept the counterfactual naively. Godwin's house is not nature; it is a laboratory, and a hothouse of a different kind. The film registers the limits of the experimental method in the figure of Felicity, the second creature Godwin and Max make while Bella is abroad. In the vocabulary of Mill's own *System of Logic* (1843), Felicity is the method of difference: an attempt to reproduce the experimental result under controlled conditions. The film marks her development as slower than Bella's. The replication fails, or at least does not repeat, and the failure is philosophically significant. Whatever Bella has become cannot be fully attributed to the experimental design. The singularity of her emancipation exceeds the method that made it possible.

Mill's liberalism carries a darker developmentalism, and the work also tests it. *On Liberty* (1859) restricts its principle of liberty to human beings "in the maturity of their faculties," excluding children and "those backward states of society in which the race itself may be considered as in its nonage," and concludes that despotism is a legitimate mode of government in dealing with barbarians, provided the end be their improvement (Mill 1859, ch. 1). The word *nonage* is Mill's English for *Unmündigkeit*, extended from children to peoples. Uday Singh Mehta and Dipesh Chakrabarty have shown how this developmental schema placed colonized peoples in what Chakrabarty calls the waiting room of history, told that self-government would come "not yet" (Mehta 1999; Chakrabarty 2000). Bella's accelerated development is a parody of the waiting room. She is promoted from infancy to adulthood in what the film presents as little more than a year, and the speed exposes the arbitrariness of every threshold of maturity by which guardianship justifies itself. Chapter Five will ask whether the film extends this critique to the colonized poor of Alexandria, or reproduces the waiting room in its own composition.

2.5 *The consent problem*

The most serious objection to the film must be stated plainly. Wedderburn, an adult man, initiates sex with Bella at a point when the film presents her understanding as a child's, and he is drawn to her by the very unguardedness that her immaturity produces; the spectator is offered these scenes in a comic register. The law of England and Wales now holds that a person consents only if she agrees by choice and has both the freedom and the capacity to make that choice (Sexual Offences Act 2003, s. 74). The film's premise places Bella's capacity in doubt, and Wedderburn exploits that doubt. By the law's standard, what he does is the sexual exploitation of a person who may be unable to consent. Critics who found the result disturbing, including those who described the film's framing as pedophilic,

are responding to something real, and an account of the film that dissolved the objection into theory would be an evasion.

The historical frame sharpens rather than dissolves it. The film's period is precisely the moment when English law renegotiated the relation between consent and maturity. In July 1885, W. T. Stead's "The Maiden Tribute of Modern Babylon" in the *Pall Mall Gazette* reported a purchase that Stead had himself arranged: through a former brothel-keeper, Rebecca Jarrett, he bought a thirteen-year-old girl, Eliza Armstrong, from her mother, to prove that children could be bought for sexual exploitation in London. Stead was later convicted of her abduction and imprisoned. Within weeks of publication, the Criminal Law Amendment Act raised the age of consent from thirteen to sixteen. The Victorian question of when a girl could consent coexisted with the older question that coverture and tutelage had always posed about adult women: whether a woman could consent to anything at all, given the "lightness of mind" that Gaius's predecessors imputed to her.

I propose that the film's strategy, deliberate or not, is to stage this older question in a body that makes it unanswerable by the usual criterion. Bella's age cannot be read from her body, and her mind changes faster than any juridical category can follow. The spectator is therefore placed in the guardian's chair, forced to ask the guardian's question, *is she capable?*, without the guardian's alibi of a fixed age. The discomfort that results is not only a response to the film; it is the affect of guardianship itself, the anxious calculation that the law of tutelage required of fathers, husbands, and judges about every woman. The film also marks the desire for the woman's immaturity as the pathology within its own story. As Bella reads Emerson and argues philosophy aboard ship, Wedderburn complains that she is losing her adorableness. He desires her *Unmündigkeit*, and when it ends his desire collapses into rage and, eventually, the asylum. The figure in the film who most resembles the spectator the critics fear is punished by the film.

This reframing does not acquit the work. A strategy that makes the spectator feel the guardian's anxiety can also convert that anxiety into a pleasurable frisson, and the film's comic tempo does not always distinguish between the two. Gray's novel, moreover, had a defense that the film forfeits. In the novel, Bella's sexual history is reported by male narrators whose reliability is impeached, and one of them is implicated: McCandless records that, while in his account she still behaves much like a twelve-year-old, she draws him into an ambiguously sexual encounter, after which he proposes marriage (Gray 1992). Victoria's letter denies the whole premise and insists that she was an adult woman throughout,

fleeing a marriage rather than emerging from infancy. By abolishing that letter, the film commits itself to the literal premise and must rely on the speed of Bella's development and on Stone's athletic, comic, deliberately de-eroticized performance to carry the scenes. My judgment is that the objection identifies a residue that the film's strategy does not wholly neutralize. That residue is the cost of literalization, and Chapter Seven will return to it as a cost the novel declined to pay.

2.6 *Conclusion: refusal is not yet freedom*

The anterior compact is the general condition of the female subject in the modern legal and philosophical order: guardianship disguised as protection, contract disguised as consent, immaturity manufactured and then imputed. *Poor Things* renders it visible by splitting the bound body from the unbound mind, and dramatizes its refusal in the Frankenstein Clause. But refusal is negative. A subject who repudiates every compact made before her creation must still become capable of making something. The next chapter turns from the compacts that awaited Bella to the capacities she developed, and to the philosophical traditions that imagined such a development.

III

The Experimental Subject

Sensation, Identity, Natality

BELLA IS AN EXPERIMENT, and the work knows the history of the experiments it repeats. This chapter situates her within five philosophical traditions that imagined a human being formed from a starting point outside history: sensationalist epistemology, the pedagogy of the feral child, Rousseau's sexed curricula, Aristotelian and Lockean metaphysics of generation and identity, and the humanism of self-fashioning from Pico to Sartre. It concludes with Hannah Arendt's concept of natality, which names what the experiment produces and the experimenter cannot control.

3.1 *The white paper and the statue*

Locke asked his reader to suppose the mind "white paper, void of all characters," and to trace every idea to experience (Locke 1690, II.i.2). Condillac radicalized the supposition in his *Traité des sensations* (1754), imagining a marble statue organized like a human being and endowed with one sense at a time, beginning with smell; offered a rose, the statue becomes, for itself, nothing but the scent of a rose. Diderot's *Lettre sur les aveugles* (1749) and the long debate over Molyneux's question, whether a man born blind and suddenly sighted could distinguish by sight a sphere from a cube he knew by touch, made the formation of the senses a laboratory of Enlightenment philosophy.

Poor Things is structured as a Condillacian sensorium, each station of the journey dedicated to a sense. Touch comes first, in Bella's discovery of her body's pleasure. Taste follows in Lisbon, where her rapture over custard tarts stages gustation as a mode of knowledge; Sor Juana Inés de la Cruz had observed, in her *Respuesta a Sor Filotea* (1691), that if Aristotle had cooked he would have written a great deal more, and Bella's epistemology begins in the kitchen. Hearing arrives with a fado singer in Lisbon, whose song produces in Bella her first experience of aesthetic melancholy, the feeling the Portuguese call *saudade*, the presence of an absence, and the first pleasure in her life that is not the satisfaction of an appetite. Motion is explored in the ballroom dance. Sight, finally, comes as moral catastrophe in Alexandria, where to see is to be wounded.

The film departs from Condillac in one decisive respect. The statue's sensations are solitary; Bella's are social from the first instant. Every pleasure she discovers is met by an interdiction: Mrs Prim's insistence that what she has found is not done in polite society, Wedderburn's attempt to correct her dancing, Godwin's anxiety about the street. Sensation, in this work, is never prior to the social law; it arrives already accompanied by a guardian. What the film adds to Condillac is the second sense that every woman learns: the sense of being watched while sensing.

3.2 *The wild child and the doctor's chair*

The Enlightenment's real experiments on unsocialized humans were conducted on children found outside society. Victor of Aveyron, captured in the forests of southern France around 1800, was entrusted to the physician Jean Itard, whose reports of 1801 and 1806 chart a pedagogy of extraordinary patience and coercion and a failure: Victor never acquired spoken language. Kaspar Hauser, who appeared in Nuremberg in 1828 claiming to have spent his childhood in a dark cell, became the Romantic counterpart, and Werner Herzog's *Jeder für sich und Gott gegen alle* (1974) made him an emblem of civilization's violence toward the innocent.

François Truffaut's *L'Enfant sauvage* (1970) is the closest formal ancestor of the film's opening section. Shot in black and white by Néstor Almendros, punctuated by archaic iris-in and iris-out transitions, it tells the story of Itard's education of Victor, and Truffaut himself plays Itard. Lanthimos's black-and-white London, with its circular vignettes and its doctor-tutor recording a creature's progress in a notebook, cites Truffaut's optics directly. The citation extends to the casting logic. In Truffaut's film, the director sits in the doctor's chair; in Lanthimos's, the actor in the doctor's chair has modeled his performance on the novel's author. In both, the authorial function and the educating function coincide in a man who observes a being he did not beget. Where the feral-child narratives end in incomplete or tragic humanization, however, *Poor Things* produces the opposite problem: a humanization so rapid and so complete that it exceeds the doctor's capacity to record it.

3.3 *Dogtooth, Attenberg, and the trunk*

Lanthimos's own *Dogtooth* (2009) is the anti-*Poor Things*. A father and mother raise three adult children inside a walled compound, teach them a falsified vocabulary in which, for example, "zombie" designates a small yellow flower, and promise that they may leave when a dogtooth falls out. The eldest daughter knocks out her own canine with a dumbbell and hides in the trunk of her father's car; the film ends on the closed trunk, never opened. *Dogtooth* stages guardianship as permanent, linguistically engineered *Unmündigkeit*, and escape as self-surgery with no assured outcome. It is fitting that Gray, after watching *Dogtooth*, judged Lanthimos fit to be trusted with his book (McIlroy 2024). The film about a daughter who cannot get out was the credential for the film about a daughter who does. *Poor Things* reopens the trunk: Wedderburn abducts Bella, carrying

her aboard ship in a steamer trunk, and when it opens it opens onto the world, onto the ship and its two philosophers.

Athina Rachel Tsangari's *Attenberg* (2010), produced by Lanthimos and featuring him in the role of a visiting engineer, supplies the other half of the ancestry. Its heroine, Marina, a twenty-three-year-old in a dying industrial town, studies human sexuality as an ethologist would, through David Attenborough's natural-history films and the instruction of her more experienced friend, whose name is Bella; the two women mimic animals in deadpan routines while Marina's father, an architect, dies. The young woman approaching sex as a natural historian, the friend named Bella, the dying father whose death completes the daughter's education: Tsangari's film anticipates the experimental eroticism and the paternal deathbed of *Poor Things* with remarkable precision. The anthropological gaze of the so-called Greek Weird Wave, its fascination with rules, rituals, and imitations, is the formal ground on which the film's comedy of manners is built.

3.4 *Émile's education for a girl*

Rousseau's *Émile* (1762) prescribed for its boy a "negative education" in which the tutor arranges the world so that the child learns from things rather than from commands. Its fifth book prescribes for Sophie the reverse: the whole education of women, Rousseau writes, ought to be relative to men, to please them, to be useful to them, to make themselves loved and honored by them (Rousseau 1762, V). Wollstonecraft devoted the fifth chapter of the *Vindication* to dismantling this program, which she read as the systematic cultivation of weakness (Wollstonecraft 1792, ch. 5).

Godwin's house contains both curricula. Mrs Prim administers Sophie's: decorum, shame, the polite society that Bella's discoveries offend. Godwin administers Émile's: observation, experiment, a world arranged so that its creature learns from consequences. Max, recording her progress, is Rousseau's tutor reduced to a scribe. Bella, by leaving the house, chooses Émile's education and pursues it beyond the tutor's reach. Montaigne had preferred, in the education of children, a head well made to a head well filled, *une tête bien faite plutôt que bien pleine* (*Essais* I.26). The phrase acquires an unintended literalness in *Poor Things*: Bella's head is, in the most material sense, well made, and the work's wager is that a well-made head need not be filled by its maker.

3.5 *Hylomorphism inverted*

Aristotle's embryology assigned to the male parent the contribution of form, soul, and movement, and to the female the contribution of matter; the female, he wrote, is as it were a deformed or mutilated male (*Generation of Animals* II.3). Galenic medicine sustained, as Thomas Laqueur showed, a one-sex model in which the female body was an inverted and imperfect version of the male (Laqueur 1990). Bella's generation dissolves both schemes. Her matter is her mother's body; her form, in the Aristotelian sense of the organizing principle of a living thing, is her own infant brain. Both are female. The male creator contributes neither matter nor form, but only *technē*, the art of joining them. Godwin's role is therefore not paternal but maieutic, in the sense of Socrates's description of himself in the *Theaetetus* as a midwife who delivers the conceptions of others without conceiving himself (*Theaetetus* 149a–151d). A woman is generated from a woman, out of a woman, by a man who is neither father nor mother but surgeon-midwife. The oldest metaphysical hierarchy of the sexes is not reversed in this operation; it is rendered inapplicable.

3.6 *The prince, the cobbler, and the general*

Locke added to the second edition of the *Essay* (1694) a chapter on identity that introduced the most consequential thought experiment in the philosophy of personal identity: if the soul of a prince, carrying the consciousness of the prince's past life, entered the body of a cobbler, everyone would see that he was the same person as the prince (Locke 1694, II.xxvii.15). Sydney Shoemaker's case of "Brownson," a man whose brain is transplanted into another's body, translated Locke's soul into neurology (Shoemaker 1963). Bernard Williams showed how such cases destabilize our intuitions once we ask which of the resulting persons we would fear to see tortured (Williams 1970), and Derek Parfit concluded that personal identity is not what matters, only psychological connectedness and continuity (Parfit 1984). Poe's Morella, it will be recalled, had already cited Locke's definition of personal identity on her way to reincarnation in her daughter.

Bella is a Brownson case with a difference that sharpens it. She has the body of Victoria Blessington and a brain that, though in one sense Victoria's offspring, carries none of Victoria's memories, character, or commitments. By the bodily criterion, she is Victoria; by Locke's and Parfit's criteria, she is someone else entirely. Blessington's claim at the wedding rests wholly on the bodily criterion, and the law of coverture,

which binds bodies, is on his side. Bella's refusal rests on the psychological criterion. The film's ending adjudicates the dispute with the logic of comic justice. While Blessington is unconscious, Bella replaces his brain with a goat's, without his consent. His body survives the operation; his person does not. He is reduced to precisely the criterion he invoked, a continuous body that no longer carries the consciousness of a general. The inverse Brownson, a body persisting without its subject, is the punishment the film devises for the man who claimed a subject on the strength of a body.

3.7 *An artisan without a concept*

Sartre's lecture "L'existentialisme est un humanisme" (1946) grounded its central formula in an analogy. A paper knife is made by an artisan who has its concept in mind; its essence precedes its existence. If God were such an artisan, human beings would be like paper knives. Since there is no God, existence precedes essence; the human being first exists and then defines itself. *Poor Things* breaks Sartre's alternative. It has a creator, whom his creature calls God, and he is precisely an artisan, but he is an artisan who declines to impose a concept on what he makes. His stance is observational rather than prescriptive; his notebooks record rather than plan. The result is a being whose existence precedes her essence despite, or rather because of, her maker's scientific restraint.

The Renaissance had imagined such a creator. In Pico della Mirandola's *Oratio de hominis dignitate* (1486), God addresses Adam: we have given you no fixed seat, no form proper to you, no peculiar function, so that you may have and possess whatever seat, form, and function you choose. Man is a chameleon, Pico continues; he may degenerate into the lower forms of life, which are brutes, or be reborn by his own decision into the higher, which are divine. Pico's Adam is the humanist subject as such, defined by indeterminacy. Bella is that subject, gendered female for the first time in the tradition's history without being restricted by the gendering. Chapter Nine will show that the film's ending stages both of Pico's vectors, the regeneration and the degeneration, in two bodies.

Beauvoir's founding claim that one becomes a woman rather than being born one finds in Bella its limit case (Beauvoir 1949). Bella becomes a person before she becomes a woman in Beauvoir's sense, that is, before she has internalized the position of the Other. She encounters the making of femininity, in Mrs Prim's lessons, Wedderburn's corrections, and Blessington's surgical plans, as an external imposition rather than as her own formation, and she can therefore refuse it. Judith Butler's account of gender as the stylized repetition of acts explains why: Bella lacks the sedimented repetitions that make gender appear natural (Butler 1990). Iris

Marion Young's phenomenology of feminine motility, with its inhibited intentionality and its discontinuous unity of body and world, describes exactly what Bella's body does not do (Young 1980). She throws, strides, kicks, and dances with a motility that has never been taught to doubt itself. Stone's choreography is, in this sense, a phenomenology of the unsocialized body.

3.8 *Natality*

Arendt grounded the human capacity for action in natality: because each human being is born as a newcomer, each is capable of beginning something new. She found the principle in Augustine, *initium ut esset homo creatus est*, that there might be a beginning, man was created (*De civitate Dei* XII.21), and she called natality the miracle that saves the world from its normal ruin (Arendt 1958). Bella is natality incarnate. Born as an adult, she appears in the world without the long apprenticeship that normally domesticates the newcomer, and she enters the space of appearance as pure beginning.

Arendt's distinction among labor, work, and action maps her trajectory with surprising exactness. Her sex work in Paris is labor in Arendt's sense: bodily, cyclical, consumed in its performance. Her medicine is work: the fabrication of durable things by a maker's hand, and surgery is fabrication in its most literal form. Her refusals and her socialism are action, the unpredictable initiation of something new among others. Arendt also inherited the Greek distinction between the household, the realm of necessity assigned to women and slaves, and the polis, the realm of freedom. Bella leaves the household for the world. The film ends, however, in a household, and Chapter Nine will argue that this is not a retreat into necessity but the refoundation of the household as a space into which action has entered.

The experimental subject, in the end, exceeds the experiment. Locke's white paper, Condillac's statue, Itard's wild boy, Rousseau's Émile, and Pico's chameleon each presupposed a designer who knew what was being made. Bella is made by a designer who chose not to know, and what she becomes is the measure of that ignorance. The next chapter turns to the domain in which the guardians' interest in her was most intense: her sexuality.

IV

Furious Jumping

The Erotics of Inquiry

BELLA'S NAME FOR SEXUAL intercourse, "furious jumping," is the work's most quoted coinage, and its comedy conceals a theory. The phrase is literal, kinetic, and free of every euphemism and every sanctity in which the nineteenth century wrapped the act; it describes sex as an observer would describe the behavior of an animal, including the observer herself. This chapter argues that Bella's sexuality is the site where the work's experimental subject meets its anterior compact most violently, and that her practice constitutes what I call an experimental *ars erotica*, a form that collapses the opposition on which Foucault built his history of sexuality.

4.1 *The apple without the fall*

In Genesis, the eating of the fruit opens the eyes of the first couple, and the first thing they know is that they are naked; knowledge arrives as shame, and the fig leaves follow (Genesis 3:6–7). Augustine made the shame constitutive: the punishment of the Fall is that the genitals no longer obey the will, so that sexual arousal, uniquely among bodily motions, rebels against its owner, and that rebellion is the origin of shame (*De civitate Dei* XIV.16–17). Milton gave Eve a prior scene of self-discovery: newly made, she sees her reflection in a pool and is drawn to it until a voice leads her away to Adam, "whose image thou art" (*Paradise Lost* IV.449–491). Self-discovery is corrected into conjugal orientation, exactly as Rousseau's Galathée relocates her "moi" in Pygmalion.

Poor Things restages the Edenic scene with a single substitution. Bella discovers masturbation with an apple, and the fruit yields knowledge without shame. Her body is not in Augustinian rebellion against her will; it is the instrument of her will, and she reports her discovery with the pride of an experimenter. Shame arrives afterward and from outside, in Mrs Prim's insistence that such things are not done in polite society. The film thus inverts Augustine's genealogy: shame is not the internal consequence of carnal knowledge but an external social law imposed on a knowledge that, left to itself, generates none. Nor is the self-discovery corrected toward a husband. Bella's pleasure is first autoerotic, and the men who later enter it are invited rather than presupposed.

The rabbinic tradition preserved a counter-Eve for whom the work also has a place. In the medieval *Alphabet of Ben Sira*, Lilith, Adam's first wife, refuses to lie beneath him on the ground that both were made from the earth, pronounces the divine Name, and flies away from Eden. Bella's departure from Godwin's house with Wedderburn is Lilithic in structure. The decisive difference is that her maker does not send angels after her. He lets her go, and she returns of her own accord.

4.2 *Scientia sexualis, ars erotica*

Foucault's *La volonté de savoir* (1976) dismantled the "repressive hypothesis" according to which the Victorians silenced sex. On the contrary, he argued, the nineteenth century incited an unprecedented proliferation of discourse about sex, organized by the confessional and medical apparatus he called *scientia sexualis*, which sought the truth of the subject in its desires. He contrasted it with the *ars erotica* of other civilizations, in which pleasure is its own truth, cultivated and transmitted through initiation rather than extracted through confession.

Bella's practice belongs to neither column and to both. Her approach to sex is scientific in method: she experiments, compares, classifies, reports, and evaluates; she treats each partner as a data point and each encounter as a trial; she coins a descriptive term in place of the euphemisms she was never taught. But the aim of the inquiry is pleasure, and its truth is not extracted by a confessor from a subject who resists it. It is produced by the subject herself, for herself. I call this an *experimental ars erotica*: pleasure pursued by the methods of natural science, without the apparatus of confession and without the master of initiation. Foucault's opposition presupposed that the scientific relation to sex is always a relation of power exercised on the subject from outside. Bella occupies both positions at once, scientist and subject, and the power relation folds back into a relation of self-knowledge.

Foucault also identified four "strategic unities" through which nineteenth-century power invested sexuality: the hysterization of women's bodies, the pedagogization of children's sex, the socialization of procreative behavior, and the psychiatrization of perverse pleasure (Foucault 1976). Ordinarily these apparatuses distribute their targets across different populations. Bella is the target of all four simultaneously. As a woman, she is the object of Blessington's surgical cure for an excessive sexuality. As a child-mind, she is the object of Mrs Prim's and Max's pedagogy of propriety. As the body of a pregnant wife, she is the residue of a procreative project. As a woman of many partners, she is pathologized by Wedderburn, who in Gray's novel concludes that she and Godwin are agents of Satan. The film collapses the four apparatuses into a single body and thereby reveals their common object: the autonomous female subject of pleasure.

4.3 *The excision*

Blessington confines Bella in his house and intends to have her clitoris surgically removed against her will, as a cure for a sexual appetite he regards as disease; the World Health Organization now classifies such an operation as a form of female genital mutilation. The surgical cure he intends was not a fantasy. In 1866 the London surgeon Isaac Baker Brown published *On the Curability of Certain Forms of Insanity, Epilepsy, Catalepsy, and Hysteria in Females*, in which he reported removing the clitoris of women in his care as a treatment for conditions he attributed to masturbation; in 1867 he was expelled from the Obstetrical Society of London, chiefly for operating without adequate consent from patients and their husbands. The scandal concerned procedure as much as principle. The underlying theory, that female sexual excess was a disease and that its organ could be excised, survived him.

It survived, in sublimated form, in psychoanalysis. Freud's *Three Essays on the Theory of Sexuality* (1905) held that the girl's transition to mature femininity required the transfer of erotic sensitivity from the clitoris to the vagina; clitoral pleasure was the mark of an immaturity to be outgrown. Anne Koedt's "The Myth of the Vaginal Orgasm" (1968) answered that the transfer was physiologically fictitious and ideologically functional. The chain of reasoning is now visible. Kant defined enlightenment as the exit from immaturity; Freud defined feminine maturity as the abandonment of the clitoris; Baker Brown and, in the film, Blessington enforced that maturity with a knife. Blessington's plan is Freud's psychic transfer executed by surgery. The developmental compact of Chapter Two here reaches its most literal and violent expression: maturity, for a woman, is the amputation of her own pleasure.

Gray's novel distributes this violence differently, and the difference is one of the most consequential decisions of the adaptation. In Victoria McCandless's letter, it is Victoria herself who, frustrated in a cold marriage, begs Godwin Baxter to perform a clitoridectomy to quiet desires that have no outlet; Godwin refuses and offers her refuge instead. The novel's realist counter-narrative thus locates the pathologization of female desire inside the woman, as an internalized imperative to mutilate herself, and makes the good surgeon the one who declines to operate. The film relocates the imperative entirely into the husband. Its version is more legible, and its villain more satisfying; the novel's is more disturbing and arguably more historically precise, since the surgical regimes of the period depended on women who had been taught to want them. Chapter Seven will return to

this transfer as an instance of the film's general method, which converts the novel's internal contradictions into external conflicts.

4.4 *The sex which is not one*

Luce Irigaray's *Ce sexe qui n'en est pas un* (1977) argued that the phallic economy, organized around the One, the visible, and the teleological, cannot represent a feminine pleasure that is plural, diffuse, and auto-affective; she figured it through the two lips that touch each other continuously, needing no instrument to be in contact with themselves. Bella's sexuality has Irigaray's structure. It begins without a man, multiplies its objects without hierarchy, and is directed toward no end, neither reproduction nor marriage nor the consolidation of a couple. Wedderburn's crisis is precisely the crisis of the phallic economy confronted with a pleasure that does not need him and cannot be totalized by him.

Hélène Cixous's "Le Rire de la Méduse" (1975) urged women to write their bodies and reread the Medusa not as a petrifying horror but as beautiful and laughing. Bella's laughter, frequent, loud, and unembarrassed, is Medusan in this sense, and her idiolect, with its literal coinages and its disregard for decorum, is a spoken *écriture féminine* before the letter. Audre Lorde's "Uses of the Erotic" (1978) supplied the decisive extension. Lorde distinguished the erotic from the pornographic, the latter being sensation without feeling, and described the erotic as a source of power and knowledge that, once acknowledged, suffuses all of a woman's work with the demand for satisfaction. This is exactly the trajectory of Bella's eros. Its object expands from the body to food, music, and dance, then to books and argument, then to the misery of Alexandria, then to politics, and finally to medicine. Bella does not sublimate her sexuality into learning; she discovers learning as a further province of the same appetite.

Alexandra Kollontai's distinction, in "Make Way for Winged Eros" (1923), between "wingless Eros," purely physical attraction, and "winged Eros," love interwoven with comradeship and social feeling, describes the same movement in socialist terms. Bella passes from wingless to winged Eros in Paris, through her friendship and sexual relationship with Toinette and the socialist meeting to which Toinette brings her. But she does not cut off the body to grow the wings. Kollontai's progression implied a hierarchy; Bella's is additive.

4.5 *The comic body*

Mikhail Bakhtin's study of Rabelais described the grotesque body of carnival as open, protruding, eating, copulating, and giving birth, a body never finished and always in the act of becoming, oriented toward the "lower bodily stratum" that official culture concealed (Bakhtin 1965). Bella's body is grotesque in exactly this technical sense. It eats with abandon, copulates without ceremony, and above all remains unfinished: the film's whole design is the representation of a body in becoming. Her body is also, literally, the site of a birth and a death at once, which is the grotesque image par excellence in Bakhtin's account.

Henri Bergson's *Le Rire* (1900) defined the comic as "something mechanical encrusted on the living," the rigidity of habit where life requires suppleness. Bella's early movements, jointed and percussive, are comic in Bergson's sense. But the film transfers the comic rigidity during its course. By Lisbon, the mechanical belongs to Wedderburn: his repeated tantrums, his stock seducer's phrases, his inability to adapt to a woman who will not stay in the role he has scripted. By the third act, rigidity has become Blessington's entire being, a man so encrusted in command that he can only repeat it. Bergson held that laughter is society's corrective of rigidity. In *Poor Things*, the corrective is turned on the men, and the woman who began as an automaton becomes the most supple creature in the film.

Sianne Ngai's aesthetic categories sharpen the analysis. The "cute," Ngai argues, is the aesthetic of powerlessness, and it solicits both tenderness and aggression; the "zany" is the aesthetic of strenuous, precarious performance (Ngai 2012). Bella's infant phase is cute in this double sense, and the men's responses to it oscillate between protection and predation. Her Lisbon dance is zany, a performance whose exuberance has an edge of exhaustion. Sara Ahmed's figure of the feminist killjoy, the one who disturbs the happiness of the table by refusing its required affect, names Bella's conduct at a genteel Lisbon dinner, where her blunt pronouncements, including a stated desire to strike a crying infant, shatter the decorum of the room (Ahmed 2010). The killjoy is an "affect alien"; Bella is alien to affects she was never taught to perform, and her alienation exposes the violence that politeness conceals.

4.6 *The sex wars restaged*

The feminist "sex wars" of the late 1970s and 1980s set the anti-pornography and abolitionist positions of Andrea Dworkin and Catharine MacKinnon against the "pro-sex" positions of Gayle Rubin,

Ellen Willis, and the organizers of the 1982 Barnard conference, whose proceedings Carole Vance published as *Pleasure and Danger* (Dworkin 1987; MacKinnon 1989; Rubin 1984; Willis 1981; Vance 1984). Vance's title describes the dramaturgy of *Poor Things* with uncanny precision. The first two acts are devoted to pleasure; the third to danger. But the danger the film locates is not in sex. It is in ownership: the lover's trunk, the husband's knife. The film's position is therefore pro-sex in Rubin's and Willis's sense while conceding the abolitionist point that the sexual relation, under conditions of male ownership, becomes a site of violence.

The film's sympathies have been criticized as too convenient, a pro-sex feminism whose images coincide with heterosexual male fantasy. The criticism has force and will not be dismissed here. Two observations qualify it. First, the film's most sustained female bond is not with a man but with Toinette, and the network of women who educate Bella, Martha, Toinette, Swiney, and finally Felicity, approximates what Adrienne Rich called the lesbian continuum, the range of woman-identified experience that compulsory heterosexuality obscures (Rich 1980). Second, the defense of the film's images cannot be conducted at the level of content, where the criticism is strongest, but only at the level of form and of the terminal turn, which are the subjects of Chapters Eight and Nine.

Furious jumping, in sum, is not a joke at the expense of sex but a joke at the expense of the apparatus that made sex a secret. It names an eros that is experimental, plural, unashamed, and expansive, and that converts every province it enters into a province of knowledge. The next chapter follows that eros into the three spaces where the world tried hardest to convert it into a commodity.

V

Heterotopias of Exchange

The Ship, the Balcony, the Brothel

Gray's drafts of March 1991 bear the title "Poor Creatures" before the book became, in a green-ink revision of the same month, *Poor Things* (McIlroy 2024). The change of a single word records the work's deepest movement. A *creature* (Latin *creatura*) belongs to the order of creation; it presupposes a creator and a theology. A *thing* (Latin *res*) belongs to the order of objects, and in the nineteenth century, preeminently, to the order of commodities. The title's revision anticipates the journey that this chapter follows: Bella passes out of the house of her creator and into a world that will try, at every station, to make her a thing. The middle of the work is an education in exchange, conducted in three spaces that Foucault taught us to call heterotopias.

5.1 *An itinerary of other spaces*

In "Des espaces autres," a lecture of 1967 published in 1984, Foucault defined heterotopias as real places that function as counter-sites, in which the other sites of a culture are simultaneously represented, contested, and inverted. He distinguished heterotopias of crisis, reserved for individuals in a critical biological state, from heterotopias of deviation, such as clinics, asylums, and prisons; he named the garden as the oldest heterotopia, a microcosm of the world; he set the brothel and the colony at the two poles of the type, the one creating a space of illusion, the other a space of compensatory order; and he concluded that the ship is the heterotopia par excellence. Among the heterotopias of crisis that survived into the nineteenth century, he listed the honeymoon trip, which allowed a young woman's deflowering to take place nowhere, on the train or in the honeymoon hotel.

Poor Things is a systematic tour of this catalogue. It begins in a heterotopia of deviation, Godwin's house-laboratory, which its production designer conceived as a reflection of its owner's love of the human body, with ears sculpted into its ceilings, wall panels patterned like cerebral folds, and rooms curved to feel engulfing and womb-like (Flew 2023). It proceeds through a heterotopia of crisis, the elopement to Lisbon, which is a honeymoon trip without a wedding, a *voyage de noces* in which the deflowering of the bride takes place literally nowhere she has a right to be. It boards the heterotopia par excellence, the ship. It descends into the colony, Alexandria under British occupation. It passes through the brothel. It visits the asylum in which Wedderburn is confined. And it ends in the oldest heterotopia of all, the garden. The work's geography is not a tourist's itinerary but an anatomy of the spaces in which a culture stores its contradictions.

5.2 *The ship of fools and its two philosophers*

Sebastian Brant's *Narrenschiff* (1494) and the painting attributed to Bosch fixed the ship as the emblem of human folly adrift, and Foucault's *Histoire de la folie* (1961) opens with the ship of fools as the figure of madness before confinement. On Bella's ship, the folly is Wedderburn's. His jealousy ripens into derangement; he gambles, rages, and at one point attacks the elderly passenger Martha von Kurtzroc, who restrains him and strikes him with her cane. The old woman's stick becomes an instrument of correction against the man.

The ship supplies Bella with two philosophers. Martha gives her Emerson, and with him a doctrine of self-trust; she tells Bella that age has moved her own concern from the body to the mind. Harry Astley, a young cynic, insists that human beings are cruel and that a clear-eyed person must arm herself with that truth. The structure is Voltaire's. Candide travels with two tutors, Pangloss, who maintains Leibniz's optimism through every catastrophe, and Martin, the Manichaean pessimist; and Candide's education begins in Lisbon, at the earthquake and the auto-da-fé (Voltaire 1759). *Poor Things* repeats the structure and reverses the city. Voltaire's Lisbon is the capital of catastrophe; Bella's is a city of custard tarts, dance, and fado, re-tiled by the production designer in red because blue had been banished from it (Flew 2023). The education by catastrophe is deferred until Alexandria.

Martha's Emerson carries its own gendered history. "Self-Reliance" (1841) commands its reader to trust himself, and declares that whoso would be a man must be a nonconformist. Its address is masculine, and Margaret Fuller, Emerson's colleague, answered it four years later in *Woman in the Nineteenth Century* (1845) by extending self-reliance to women without exception: "let them be sea-captains, if you will." Bella reading Emerson aboard ship enacts Fuller's appropriation in the most literal setting available. The casting of Martha adds a further layer. Hanna Schygulla was Fassbinder's Effi Briest (1974), the heroine of Fontane's novel of 1895 whom a husband's honor code destroys. The actress who once embodied the canon's punished wife now plays the old woman who survives, reads, and teaches.

Harry's cynicism has its own lineage, from the Cynics who took their name from the dog, *kyōn*, to Schopenhauer's metaphysics of suffering. In Gray's novel the corresponding figure is the Englishman Astley, whose name recalls the phlegmatic Mr. Astley of Dostoevsky's *The Gambler* (1866), a novel about the casino; Gray's Astley tries to win Bella to a Malthusian and imperialist view of the world's misery, and she becomes a

socialist instead (Gray 1992). The film's Harry is a young Black American whose pessimism is existential rather than economic. The change matters, as the next section shows.

5.3 *The view from the balcony*

In Alexandria, Harry leads Bella to a vantage point above the city's poor, among whom are dead infants. She breaks down, and Harry holds her back. The scene is the moral center of the film and its most exposed point. Its structure is that of the panorama, the European gaze from above that Edward Said placed at the heart of Orientalism, in which the East serves as a theater for Western self-knowledge (Said 1978).

The literary precedent is *King Lear*. Exposed on the heath, the king recognizes for the first time the "poor naked wretches" whom his reign ignored, and prescribes a cure for the powerful: "Take physic, pomp; / Expose thyself to feel what wretches feel, / That thou mayst shake the superflux to them" (*King Lear* III.iv). Bella does precisely this. She gathers Wedderburn's casino winnings and gives them to two crewmen who promise to deliver them to the poor, and who pocket them. The film thus stages Lear's remedy and its failure in a single gesture. Oscar Wilde had made the argument in "The Soul of Man Under Socialism" (1891): charitable remedies do not cure the disease of poverty but prolong it, and the proper aim is to reconstruct society on a basis on which poverty is impossible. Bella's itinerary dramatizes Wilde's essay. She proceeds from charity in Alexandria to socialism in Paris, from shaking the superflux to analyzing its production.

The film nevertheless reproduces the structure it criticizes. No Egyptian speaks in the sequence; the poor are a mass, an image, an occasion for the heroine's anguish. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's question, whether the subaltern can speak, finds here an answer in the negative (Spivak 1988). Spivak's reading of *Frankenstein* is pertinent as well. She drew attention to Safie, the Arabian woman whose flight from her father to Christian Europe is the vehicle through which Shelley's creature learns of history and empire from Volney's *Ruins* (Spivak 1985). The Alexandria sequence repeats the Safie structure in reverse: the European woman learns of injustice by gazing on the Arab poor, who remain instruments of her education. Sylvia Wynter's critique of the "overrepresentation of Man," the elevation of the Western bourgeois subject into the measure of the human, names the limit (Wynter 2003). Bella's humanism is universal in aspiration and European in its vantage.

The comparison with the novel sharpens the point. Gray gave the Alexandrian scene an explicit ideological antagonist, Astley's Malthusian

imperialism, the doctrine that misery and vice are nature's checks on population, against which Bella's socialism defines itself (Malthus 1798; Gray 1992). The film replaces that antagonist with a generalized pessimism about human nature and thereby loses the imperial political economy that made the misery legible as a product of empire rather than of the species. The casting introduces a further ambiguity. Harry and Toinette, Bella's two political tutors, are played by Black actors, Jerrod Carmichael and Suzy Bemba. One reading sees a deliberate inversion of Victorian racial hierarchy, in which those whom the period's science placed lowest become the bearers of knowledge. Another sees the familiar figure of the racialized mentor whose interior life is subordinated to a white protagonist's development, the figure that Spike Lee's critique popularized as the "magical Negro," a pattern long criticized in the analysis of cinematic representation (hooks 1992). The film supports both readings, with one asymmetry: Harry's cynicism is given a wound whose causes the film never explores, and he is left behind at Marseille, while Toinette brings Bella to socialism and is present in the final household. The balcony view, in sum, is the condition of the humanist subject: one sees the poor from above. The film's honesty lies in the irony of the pocketed money. The European gaze's gift does not reach its object.

5.4 *The brothel and the speaking commodity*

Ejected from the ship at Marseille, Bella and Wedderburn arrive destitute in a perpetually snowing Paris, and Bella takes employment at a brothel run by Madame Swiney. The setting is historically precise. The French system of regulated prostitution, the *maisons de tolérance* supervised by the *police des mœurs*, had been codified in the hygienist science of Alexandre Parent-Duchâtelet, whose *De la prostitution dans la ville de Paris* (1836) studied prostitutes with the same statistical method he applied to the city's sewers; Alain Corbin later reconstructed the system's history (Corbin 1978). Britain imported regulationism through the Contagious Diseases Acts of 1864, 1866, and 1869, against which Josephine Butler's Ladies' National Association campaigned until their repeal in 1886. Parent-Duchâtelet made the prostitute an object of medical knowledge. Bella, the prostitute who becomes a physician, inverts his gaze.

The set is a document of that inversion. The walls of Bella's room were covered with a thick, fur-lined paper that recorded every hand that touched it, so that what appear on screen as handprints pressed into plaster are the traces of craftspeople, visitors, and the actors playing her clients (Flew 2023). The brothel is literally an archive of hands, the place in

the film where the possessive hand of Chapter Two leaves its marks most densely, and from which Bella will depart toward the hand of the surgeon.

The Marxist theory of the family had already identified marriage and prostitution as two forms of one transaction. Engels argued that monogamy arose with private property and constituted the world-historical defeat of the female sex, and that the bourgeois wife differs from the ordinary courtesan only in that she does not hire out her body by the piece as a wage worker, but sells it once and for all into slavery (Engels 1884). The *Communist Manifesto* had put it more briefly: the bourgeois sees in his wife a mere instrument of production (Marx and Engels 1848). When Wedderburn tries to shame Bella for her work, she answers that the women are their own means of production. The line is the Manifesto's sentence turned inside out. The instrument of production declares itself the owner of the means.

Marx himself once let the commodity talk. In the first chapter of *Capital*, he imagines that if commodities could speak, they would say that their use value may interest human beings but does not belong to them as objects, whereas their value does (Marx 1867, I.1.4). The ventriloquism is ironic; commodities cannot speak, and their silence is the condition of the fetishism that makes relations between people appear as relations between things. Luce Irigaray took Marx's figure literally in "Le marché des femmes" and "Des marchandises entre elles" (1977), arguing that the exchange of women as commodities founds the social order among men; that women are assigned three roles in it, the mother as use value, the virgin as pure exchange value, and the prostitute as both at once; and that the decisive political question is what would happen if the goods refused to go to market. Bella occupies all three of Irigaray's roles in one body. She is bodily a mother, the pregnant Victoria; she is betrothed as a virgin bride to Max; she becomes a prostitute in Paris. And she does what Marx's commodities could only be imagined to do: she speaks, and her speech is analysis. *Poor Things* is the *Bildungsroman* of Marx's speaking commodity, and the revision of its title from "creatures" to "things" records the passage it narrates.

The film does not idealize the brothel. Bella proposes to reverse the direction of choice in the house, so that the women would select their clients rather than be selected, and the proposal is refused; Swiney understands that the clients are paying, among other things, for the power to choose. Carole Pateman's analysis of the prostitution contract as the sale of command over a body applies with full force, and the film's Swiney, a tattooed survivor who exploits and instructs in equal measure, is its embodiment (Pateman 1988). She recalls the Old Woman of *Candide*, who

narrates a lifetime of sexual violence with ironic detachment, and the casting reinforces the association with older female powers: Kathryn Hunter had played all three witches in Joel Coen's *The Tragedy of Macbeth* (2021). Emma Goldman's "The Traffic in Women" (1910) had argued that it is merely a question of degree whether a woman sells herself to one man, in or out of marriage, or to many; Beauvoir's chapter on prostitutes and hetaeras described the prostitute as the scapegoat whose degradation guarantees the respectability of the wife (Goldman 1910; Beauvoir 1949). Between the abolitionist position of Pateman and the sex-worker-rights position that came to be named, from the late 1970s, by the phrase "sex work," the film takes a third line. The problem it identifies is not sex, nor even sale, but ownership: who owns the means, and who chooses.

5.5 *The courtesan who does not die*

The canon of the Paris courtesan is a canon of deaths. Hogarth's *A Harlot's Progress* (1732) follows Moll Hackabout from her arrival in London to her death of venereal disease. Dumas fils's *La Dame aux camélias* (1848) and Verdi's *La traviata* (1853) kill their heroine with consumption; Zola's *Nana* (1880) with smallpox. In Godard's *Vivre sa vie* (1962), Nana, a Parisian prostitute, discusses the philosophy of language with Brice Parain in a café and is shot dead in the street. In Buñuel's *Belle de jour* (1967), Séverine works afternoons in Madame Anaïs's house in pursuit of a masochistic fantasy that the film never fully separates from its director's. Bella is, in Paris, both of Godard's and Buñuel's heroines at once, a prostitute-philosopher and a *belle* in a madam's house, and she escapes both endings. She is not shot, and she is not folded back into bourgeois marriage. She leaves Paris alive, with a political education and a vocation.

Hogarth's companion series, *A Rake's Progress* (1735), ends in Bedlam, its last plate showing Tom Rakewell raving in the madhouse. Wedderburn, the film's rake, ends in an asylum, where Max finds him on his way to finding Bella. The work thus completes the rake's progress and inverts the harlot's. The man who believed himself a libertine is destroyed by the woman's freedom; the woman whom the moral order would have destroyed walks out of the brothel toward the operating theater.

5.6 *Three lessons in exchange*

The three heterotopias constitute a single education. On the ship, Bella learns that ideas circulate as positions, optimism and pessimism traded like the casino's chips. On the balcony, she learns the global distribution of misery, and that a gift given from above does not reach those below. In the

brothel, she learns the female body as commodity and discovers that the commodity can speak. Her responses trace a sequence: from charity, which redistributes value; to analysis, which explains its production; to medicine, which repairs bodies. The last term matters most for the argument of this thesis. Bella's ethical development culminates not in a better theory of exchange but in an operative practice on the body, and it is to the body from which she came that the next chapter returns.

VI

The Mother's Body

Matricide, Revenance, and the Canon of Feminine Death

Bella's adventure takes her across the Mediterranean, but her deepest journey is backward, into the life of the woman whose body she inhabits. This chapter reads that journey as an anamnesis, a recovery of the maternal past, and argues that it ends in what I call *anamnestic refusal*: Bella recovers her mother's story, avenges her mother's suffering, and declines to become her mother. The chapter begins with the literary archive from which Bella's body was, in a sense, retrieved, and ends with the two dramatic precedents that her story most precisely inverts, Aeschylus's *Oresteia* and Shakespeare's *The Winter's Tale*.

6.1 *The archive of drowned heroines*

The Introduction placed the film's opening leap within the Victorian iconography of the drowned fallen woman. The literary archive behind that iconography is wider and longer. Gertrude's report of Ophelia's drowning (*Hamlet* IV.vii) furnished its archetype. George Eliot drowned Maggie Tulliver with her brother in the flood that ends *The Mill on the Floss* (1860). Kate Chopin's Edna Pontellier, having awakened to her own desire and art, swims out into the Gulf at the close of *The Awakening* (1899). Virginia Woolf's first novel, *The Voyage Out* (1915), sends a sheltered young woman, Rachel Vinrace, on a sea voyage that is also her sentimental and intellectual education, and kills her with a fever at its end; Woolf herself walked into the River Ouse in 1941. Where the heroines do not drown, they die by other means: Emma Bovary by arsenic, Anna Karenina under a train, Effi Briest of a wasting illness after her husband's honor has been satisfied, and, in Voltaire's *L'Ingénu* (1767), Mademoiselle de Saint-Yves of grief after yielding her body to a minister to free the man she loves.

The pattern was not lost on feminist criticism. The editors of *The Voyage In* (1983) observed that narratives of female development persistently terminate in death or withdrawal where the male *Bildungsroman* terminates in integration (Abel, Hirsch, and Langland 1983). Bronfen's analysis showed that the dead woman is not an accident of plot but a requirement of the aesthetic order (Bronfen 1992). I propose to call this requirement the *canonical compact*: a form of anterior compact inscribed not in law but in narrative convention, by which the plot of a woman who desires was signed before she was born. The sexual heroine of the nineteenth-century novel enters her story already contracted to die in it.

Poor Things is born from the corpse of this compact. Its opening leap is the last scene of the canonical plot, and the work proceeds as a sequel that the canon never authorized. *The Awakening* ends where *Poor Things* begins: Edna swims out, and Victoria leaps. *The Voyage Out* sends its heroine to sea

for an education and kills her; *Poor Things* sends its heroine to sea for an education and returns her to a vocation. The resurrection is not of one woman but of a genre's victim. Bella rises from the Thames as the revenant of an entire archive.

6.2 *Putney Bridge: the woman who survived the leap*

The archive contains one figure who leaped and lived. Mary Wollstonecraft's attempt from Putney Bridge in October 1795, described in Chapter One, was followed by two of the most productive years of her life, by her marriage to Godwin, and by the birth of the daughter whose delivery killed her. Wollstonecraft is the historical revenant behind Bella: the drowned woman who came back and wrote. William Godwin's *Memoirs* reanimated her once more after her death, and in doing so exposed her to a century of contempt. The pattern of the loving male reanimator whose reanimation is also an exposure passes into the film's Godwin and Max, who document Bella's every development in their notebooks. The film is careful to show that documentation is not possession. But it does not let us forget that the first form of Bella's existence was as a case.

6.3 *Matricide and the uninhabitable home*

Luce Irigaray argued, against Freud's myth of the primal patricide, that Western culture is founded on a matricide, whose archetypal scene is Orestes's murder of Clytemnestra; the symbolic order requires that the daughter be severed from the mother and that the mother's body be silenced (Irigaray 1981). Bella's origin literalizes this founding gesture with clinical exactness. The mother's mind is discarded; her body is appropriated by a man whom the daughter will call God; the daughter is installed in the vacated body. The patriarchal symbolic's primal act, in Irigaray's account, is here performed with a scalpel.

The matricide is complicated, however, by the mother's own act. Victoria chose to die, and to take her unborn child with her. Godwin's operation overrides that choice: it preserves the child the mother had decided not to bear and installs it in the body the mother had decided to destroy. The work's founding freedom therefore rests on the annulment of a woman's decision, and the film does not conceal this. It is the most uncomfortable fact in the work, and its honesty about it is one of the reasons the work exceeds the comedy it often resembles.

Julia Kristeva described the subject's constitution as an *abjection* of the maternal body, a separation enacted through disgust and expulsion

(Kristeva 1980). Bella cannot abject a mother whom she inhabits, and this is why she is uncanny in the strict Freudian sense. Freud observed that the female genitals are uncanny to men because they are the entrance to the former home, the *Heim*, of every human being, and cited the saying that love is homesickness (Freud 1919). Bella does not merely remember the *Heim*; she lives in it. Her body is her mother's, and the house in which she was reanimated, Godwin's, was designed, according to its production designer, to feel engulfing and womb-like (Flew 2023). She is gestated twice, in a woman's body and in a man's house built as a womb, and the film's last scene will show her taking possession of the second.

Adrienne Rich, borrowing a term from Lynn Sukenick, named the daughter's fear of becoming her mother *matrophobia* (Rich 1976). Nancy Chodorow explained how mothering reproduces itself across generations through the daughter's identification with the mother (Chodorow 1978). Bella's visit to Blessington's house is a confrontation with both. She steps into her mother's life, her husband, her servants, her name, and she is invited to resume it. She does not flee in matrophobic horror, nor does she reproduce the maternal position. She studies it, and she declines it.

6.4 *The anamnesis: wallpaper, vertigo, and the name*

Blessington's house is the prison that Victoria escaped by leaping, and he now confines Bella in it. Its literary model is Charlotte Perkins Gilman's "The Yellow Wall-Paper" (1892), in which a physician-husband confines his wife to a rest cure of the kind prescribed by S. Weir Mitchell, and she ends creeping along the walls behind which she imagines other women trapped. Victoria's interior life is never shown directly; it is legible only in traces: in the fear in which Blessington keeps his servants, the rules he enforces, and the pistol he keeps at hand. The film presents her suicide as an escape from his abuse. Bella reconstructs her mother as an archaeologist reconstructs a life from a house.

Blessington's demand is that Bella become Victoria again. The cinematic precedent is Hitchcock's *Vertigo* (1958), in which Scottie forces Judy to remake herself, in clothes, hair, and bearing, into the dead Madeleine; Laura Mulvey's analysis of the film made it the textbook case of sadistic voyeurism and fetishistic reconstruction of the female body (Mulvey 1975). Lanthimos had treated the impersonation of the dead in *Alps* (2011), where a small company hires itself out to play the deceased for the bereaved. Blessington wants a *Vertigo* performance and an *Alps* service. He wants his dead wife back, and he is indifferent to the fact that the woman before him has never been his wife.

The name is the hinge of the confrontation, as it was in Poe's "Morella." To be called Victoria is to become Victoria, and to become Victoria is to be returned to the life that ended in the river. Bella refuses the name as Poe's daughter could not. In this refusal she also answers the century's most famous dramatic exchange about a woman's identity. In Ibsen's *A Doll's House* (1879), Torvald tells Nora that before all else she is a wife and a mother; Nora replies that she believes that before all else she is a human being, or must try to become one. Bella has learned that she was, bodily, a wife and a mother before she was anything at all. She chooses Nora's answer.

6.5 *The father as husband*

The film never states it, but its logic implies it: the child whom Victoria carried was presumably Blessington's, and the brain that thinks in Bella is therefore his daughter's. When Blessington claims Bella as his wife, he is, by this logic, a father claiming his daughter as a wife. The incest structure is the patriarchal claim stripped of its disguises. Claude Lévi-Strauss made the prohibition of incest the foundation of the exchange of women, the rule that compels men to give their daughters and sisters away and so to form alliances (Lévi-Strauss 1949). Blessington's claim violates the founding prohibition of the system on which his title rests. The anterior compact, pressed to its conclusion, contradicts itself. The Name-of-the-Father that Lacan placed at the foundation of the symbolic order here appears in its most literal and most monstrous form, as a father's name demanding to be borne by his daughter as his wife (Lacan 1966). The film's tact in leaving the structure implicit is not evasion. It allows the spectator to discover, as Bella discovers her mother, what the claim of the husband was always also capable of meaning.

6.6 *The Oresteia inverted*

In the *Eumenides*, the trial of Orestes for the murder of his mother turns on a theory of generation. Apollo argues that the mother is not the parent of the child but only the nurse of the newly planted seed; the father is the true parent (*Eumenides* 658–661). Athena, born from the head of Zeus without a mother, casts the deciding vote for Orestes on the ground that she is for the male in all things (*Eumenides* 736–738). The Furies, the ancient female powers who pursued the matricide, are then persuaded to accept a home beneath Athens and a new name, the Kindly Ones. The trilogy that Irigaray read as the charter of matricide ends with the domestication of female rage.

Poor Things inverts the trilogy point by point. Its generation contradicts Apollo's theory: the mother here is not the nurse of a male seed but the whole material substrate of the child's existence, and the child's form is her own. Its avenger is not a son who kills his mother to avenge his father, but a daughter who punishes her father-husband on her mother's behalf. And its ending does not house the Furies; it houses the patriarch. The general, his mind replaced, is given a place in Bella's garden and grazes there. Where Aeschylus domesticated the female powers to found the city, Lanthimos and McNamara domesticate the father to found a household.

6.7 *The Winter's Tale: a resurrection and a reunion*

Shakespeare's late romance offers the other precedent. Leontes, consumed by jealousy, destroys his wife Hermione, who is reported dead; their infant daughter Perdita is abandoned. Sixteen years later, Paulina, Hermione's loyal woman, unveils a statue of the queen that moves, breathes, and descends, and Leontes, awestruck, prays that if this be magic it be "an art / Lawful as eating" (*The Winter's Tale* V.iii). Mother and daughter are reunited. The play also contains the period's most famous debate on the ethics of art and nature, in which Polixenes defends the grafting of plants against Perdita's objection, a debate to which Chapter Nine will return.

Poor Things is a *Winter's Tale* in which the resurrected wife is the lost daughter, so that the reunion of mother and daughter takes place within a single body. Its resurrecting magician is a man rather than a woman: Godwin occupies the place of Paulina, and the substitution measures the distance between Shakespeare's female custodian of the hidden wife and the nineteenth century's male physician. And its tyrant is not forgiven but transformed. Leontes is restored to his family through penitence; Bella destroys Blessington's mind, and with it any possibility of penitence. Shakespeare's comedy of forgiveness becomes Lanthimos's comedy of erasure.

6.8 *Anamnestic refusal*

The three movements of Bella's return to her mother can now be stated precisely. She recovers the mother's story, which the canonical compact had sealed in the river. She avenges the mother's suffering on the man who caused it. And she refuses identity with the mother, declining both her name and her life. This is a daughter's genealogy without matrophobia, since she does not flee the mother in horror, and without reproduction, since she does not repeat her. It is built, uneasily, on a matricidal foundation that the work refuses to hide. The next chapter turns from the

body of the mother to the body of the book, and to the woman in Gray's novel who answered the men's story of her making with a story of her own.

VII

Gray's Anatomy

Metafiction, Nation, and the Scriptorial Hand

THE FILM IS THE more famous body of *Poor Things*, but the novel is the more complex one, and the film's achievements and costs can be measured only against it. This chapter reconstructs the novel's documentary apparatus, its Scottish genealogy, its national allegory, and its Menippean form; it reads Victoria McCandless's letter as the work of a fourth hand, the scriptorial; and it formulates the principle by which the film transforms the book.

7.1 *An anatomy by Gray*

The novel presents itself as an edited document. Its fictional editor, "Alasdair Gray," explains in his introduction that the historian Michael Donnelly, assistant to Elspeth King at the People's Palace, Glasgow's museum of social history, rescued a heap of old box files from a pavement where they awaited destruction by the Cleansing Department. Among them was a privately printed book of 1909, the memoir of Archibald McCandless, illustrated with etchings attributed to William Strang, and a letter written by McCandless's widow, Victoria, contradicting it. King and Donnelly were real people, and Gray had worked under King in 1977 as Glasgow's official Artist-Recorder for the People's Palace (Procter 2008). The editor and Donnelly disagree: the editor holds the memoir to be history, and Donnelly the letter. The book is completed by "Notes Critical and Historical" and by illustrations that Gray drew himself while attributing them to Strang, interleaved with punning fragments of plates from *Gray's Anatomy*; later paperback editions added a page of reviews, some patently invented, under a printed erratum strip (Gray 1992; McIlroy 2024).

The pun of the anatomical plates is the key to the form. Henry Gray's *Anatomy: Descriptive and Surgical* (1858) gave the English-speaking world its standard map of the dissected body; Alasdair Gray's *Poor Things* gives the reader an anatomy of the Victorian body politic, and the author's surname makes the generic identification inevitable. The book is "Gray's anatomy" in both senses: a dissection, and a work by Gray. Its author, who described himself as "a maker of imagined objects," made the book itself an object assembled from heterogeneous parts, like the creatures it describes (McIlroy 2024).

The archive records how the assemblage was made. In March 1991 Gray drafted a short story called "Poor Creatures"; by the end of that month it had become "Poor Things," announced as a novella and three stories; a draft of June 1991 contained the main characters at about half the final length; and the framing account by the editor and the retrospective narrative of Bella-as-Victoria were completed by March 1992 (McIlroy

2024). The woman's counter-narrative, in other words, was grafted onto the man's fantasy late in the process of composition. The novel's structure of male story and female refutation reproduces the order of its writing.

7.2 *Found manuscripts and Scottish doubles*

The found-manuscript device is as old as the novel; Cervantes attributed *Don Quixote* to the Arab historian Cide Hamete Benengeli. But Gray's use of it belongs to a specifically Scottish tradition. James Macpherson's *Ossian* poems of the 1760s, presented as translations of an ancient Gaelic bard, made a fabricated document the founding text of Scottish literary modernity. James Hogg's *The Private Memoirs and Confessions of a Justified Sinner* (1824), which the National Library of Scotland's curator names among Gray's precedents (McIlroy 2024), supplied the exact structure: an editor's narrative, a sinner's memoir that contradicts it, and an editor's conclusion in which a letter signed by "James Hogg" appears and the author himself, encountered by the editor's party, gruffly declines to help. Hogg put himself into the frame of his own book; Gray did the same, as editor.

Hogg's novel is also the founding Scottish text of the divided self, the line that runs through Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886) and that G. Gregory Smith named, in 1919, the "Caledonian antisyzygy," the zigzag of contradictions he took to characterize the Scottish imagination, a phrase Hugh MacDiarmid later adopted as a program (Smith 1919). Bella and Victoria are the antisyzygy embodied: two persons in one body, two narratives of one life, two documents in one book, each contradicting the other. Gray's novel is a Scottish double in the tradition of Hogg and Stevenson, reconceived around a woman.

7.3 *Bella Caledonia*

Gray was a socialist and a Scottish nationalist, and in 1992 he published, alongside *Poor Things*, the pamphlet *Why Scots Should Rule Scotland*. His adaptation of a line by the Canadian poet Dennis Lee, enjoining his readers to work as though they lived in the early days of a better nation, had already become, in Christopher Harvie's account, a slogan of Scottish resistance to Thatcherism, and it was later carved into the Canongate Wall of the Scottish Parliament (Procter 2008). Among Gray's drafts for the novel is an illustration titled "Bella Caledonia" (McIlroy 2024).

The national allegory follows. Bella is a mature body governed by an infantilized mind, or, as the allegory might put it, an ancient nation whose political will had been placed in tutelage since the Union of 1707; her story

is a story of the recovery of self-government. Critics have read the novel in these terms, as an inquiry into Scotland, storytelling, and selfhood (Kaczvinsky 2001), and have noted that where Scotland is peripheral to *Frankenstein*, it is central to Gray, whose novel unsettles the opposition of margin and center that structures Shelley's book and dwells on Scotland's ambiguous postcolonial status (Procter 2008). Chapter One observed that Shelley's female creature was made and destroyed in the Orkneys. Gray brings her back to Glasgow and makes her the figure of a nation.

The film removes Scotland entirely. Its London is a fantasy city, its Max is McCandles rather than McCandless, and nothing in it invites a national reading. The erasure has been regretted, with reason. But it can also be described as a translation of the allegory's vehicle. In the film, the tutelage from which Bella emerges is not a nation's but a sex's, and the self-government she achieves is not home rule but self-rule, the *selbmundia* that the Edict of Rothari denied to women. The film keeps the structure of the allegory and changes its referent from Caledonia to Bella herself.

7.4 *Menippean anatomy*

Northrop Frye identified four forms of prose fiction, and called the fourth the anatomy, or Menippean satire: a form concerned with mental attitudes rather than characters, encyclopedic, digressive, and intellectually aggressive, whose exemplary instance is Burton's *Anatomy of Melancholy* (Frye 1957). Mikhail Bakhtin, in his study of Dostoevsky, enumerated the features of the *menippea*: fantastic situations invented to test a philosophical idea; the combination of that fantasy with "slum naturalism," the world of brothels, taverns, and thieves' dens; observation of the world from an unusual vantage point, often from a height; moral and psychological experimentation, including madness and split personality; scandal scenes; oxymoronic combinations such as the virtuous courtesan; inserted genres such as letters; elements of social utopia; and pointed topicality (Bakhtin 1963).

The list reads like an analytic table of contents for *Poor Things*. The fantastic premise tests a philosophical idea about the formation of a woman. The brothel supplies slum naturalism; the Alexandrian balcony supplies the view from a height; Wedderburn's derangement supplies the madness, and Bella-Victoria the split self. The interrupted wedding is the scandal scene. Bella is the virtuous courtesan. The letters are the inserted genres. The socialism is the utopia, and the Scottish politics of 1992 the topicality. Dostoevsky, Bakhtin's own exemplary author, is present through a name: Gray's Astley recalls the Englishman of *The Gambler*.

Gray's novel is an anatomy in Frye's sense, a menippea in Bakhtin's, and "Gray's anatomy" in its own.

7.5 *The letter*

Victoria McCandless's letter is the novel's fourth hand. It tells another story. Victoria grew up in Manchester under an abusive father and an education designed to make her a perfect wife. Her marriage to Blessington was cold, and left her sexually frustrated and alone. She sought out Godwin Baxter, a gifted surgeon but no Frankenstein, and begged him to remove her clitoris in order to quiet desires that had no outlet; he refused, and offered her refuge if she needed to leave her husband. She fled to his house and fell in love with him, though he did not return her love. She did travel with Godwin, and she did run away with Wedderburn; she married McCandless because she could not marry Godwin, because a husband would ease her life and career, and because she did not wish to be lonely. She became an accomplished physician and the mother of three sons, while McCandless drifted. His book, she concludes, was a fantasy written to console himself for his own aimlessness. The editor's final note adds that she became a committed socialist, wrote controversial medical pamphlets, and lived until 1946 (Gray 1992).

Tzvetan Todorov defined the fantastic as the hesitation of a reader who knows only natural laws before an apparently supernatural event; when the hesitation resolves in favor of natural explanation, the genre becomes the uncanny, and when it resolves in favor of the supernatural, the marvelous (Todorov 1970). Gray's novel sustains the hesitation to its last page. The memoir and the letter cannot both be true; the editor and Donnelly disagree; and the notes support each version in turn. Philip Hobsbaum read the book through the paradigm of the unreliable narrator, and the unreliability is distributed across every voice, including Victoria's (Hobsbaum 1995).

The letter is the scriptorial hand. Barbara Johnson argued that a woman's autobiography is structurally the monster writing itself, since the culture's available image of the self-representing woman is monstrous (Johnson 1982); Gilbert and Gubar described the woman writer's "anxiety of authorship" before a tradition that made the pen a metaphorical penis (Gilbert and Gubar 1979). Victoria seizes the pen and writes the monster out of existence. Her letter does not refute the men's account of her by fighting within it; it refutes the account as such, from outside, denying the premise of her manufacture. I call this a *transcendent refutation*. Its power is epistemic: it returns to the woman the authority to say what happened to her. Its limit is structural: the letter is enclosed between two men's frames,

the editor's introduction and the editor's notes, and the dispute over its truth is conducted by two men, the editor and Donnelly. The woman's voice enters the book as a document whose credibility men adjudicate.

7.6 *Adaptation as graft: the letter and the goat*

The film's relation to this structure can now be specified. It makes three excisions: the documentary frame with Victoria's letter, Scotland, and Todorovian hesitation, so that the novel's fantastic becomes the film's marvelous. It makes two major inventions: the chromatic regime that ties color to Bella's experience, and the ending in which Bella replaces Blessington's brain with a goat's; in the novel, Blessington simply dies (Gray 1992). And it makes a series of transfers that follow a single principle. The film converts the novel's internal contradictions into external conflicts.

The principle is visible in every transfer. In the novel, the wish to excise the clitoris is Victoria's own, an internalized pathology that the good surgeon refuses to serve; in the film, it is Blessington's plan, imposed from outside. In the novel, Astley's Malthusian imperialism is an ideology Bella must think her way out of; in the film, Harry's pessimism is a temperament she must outgrow. In the novel, the truth of Bella's making is an epistemic dispute between two men over a woman's document; in the film, it is a plot in which men compete for her body. And in the novel, the woman refutes the men's fantasy by writing; in the film, she refutes their power by operating. Gray's book culminates in a letter. Lanthimos's film culminates in a goat.

The two endings constitute the two hands of what I have called a bimanual feminism. The scriptorial hand refutes the fantasy from outside; the surgical hand refutes power from within it. The novel's refutation is transcendent and epistemic; the film's is *immanent* and operative. Neither is sufficient alone. The letter preserves the woman's authority over her own story but leaves her body to the men's narrative and her credibility to their judgment. The goat ends the men's power over her body but accepts the men's fantasy of her making as the condition of her life. The film's cost, already identified in Chapter Two, follows from this choice: by abandoning the letter, it forfeits the novel's defense against the charge of infantilization, and commits itself to the literal premise.

The word that joins the two hands is *graft*. English "graft" descends, through Old French, from Latin *graphium*, the stylus, and Greek *grapheion*, a writing implement; the horticultural scion was named for its resemblance to a pen. Jacques Derrida, meditating on the citational structure of texts, wrote that to write means to graft, and that the two are the same word

(Derrida 1972). Gray's novel is a textual graft, composed of Shelley, Hogg, Dostoevsky, Strang's portraits, and Gray's *Anatomy*; Lanthimos's film is a bodily graft, composed of a woman, a fetus, a goose, a dog, a man, and a goat. Adaptation itself, Linda Hutcheon's repetition without replication, is a graft of one medium onto another (Hutcheon 2006). Gray had grafted the story onto film once already: with Sandy Johnson, he wrote a screenplay between 1994 and 1996 that was never produced and that he later published in *A Gray Playbook* (2009), and it was only after seeing *Dogtooth* that he judged Lanthimos fit to be trusted with the book (McIlroy 2024). The work exists, then, in three bodies, and the film we have is a graft upon a graft.

The novel's last word belongs to a woman with a pen, and the film's to a woman with a scalpel. The etymology of graft suggests that these are not two instruments but two uses of one. The next chapter examines how the film's form, its color, lenses, sets, and sounds, performs the surgical hand at the level of the image.

VIII

Suture and Scar

The Cinematic Graft

IF THE NOVEL'S FORM is an anatomy, the film's is an operation. This chapter argues that Lanthimos's style, often described as "clinical," is surgical in a precise sense: it cuts visibly, joins visibly, and refuses the invisible seams of classical continuity. Its emblem is Godwin's face, a patchwork of scars that shows how it was made. The chapter situates the film within its director's oeuvre and its writer's idiom, analyzes its chromatic, optical, scenographic, and sonic regimes, confronts the debate over its gaze, and closes with a comparative cinema of the made woman.

8.1 *A surgical cinema*

Lanthimos's films are anatomies of institutions. *Kinetta* (2005) followed a trio who restage crimes; *Dogtooth* (2009) sealed a family inside a compound and a falsified language; *Alps* (2011) followed a company that impersonates the dead. The English-language films enlarged the scale without changing the method. In *The Lobster* (2015), single people who fail to find a partner within forty-five days are surgically transformed into animals of their choice. In *The Killing of a Sacred Deer* (2017), a cardiac surgeon who killed a patient on his table must sacrifice a member of his own family. In *The Favourite* (2018), written with Tony McNamara and Deborah Davis, Queen Anne keeps seventeen rabbits, one for each child she has lost. *Kinds of Kindness* (2024) returned to the triptych of submission and control.

Poor Things inverts each of these motifs. *The Lobster* turned people into animals as the punishment for refusing compulsory coupledom; *Poor Things* turns a man into an animal as the punishment for enforcing it. *Sacred Deer* made the surgeon's hand the source of guilt and the occasion of a sacrifice; *Poor Things* gives the scalpel to a woman, who uses it to destroy her abuser's mind. *The Favourite* substituted animals for dead children; *Poor Things* lets the dead child live in the mother's body. *Dogtooth* ended on a closed trunk; *Poor Things* opens it. The film is, in this sense, the reversal of its director's prior work, and Gray's judgment that the maker of *Dogtooth* could be trusted with his book has a structural justification (McIlroy 2024). Stone's collaboration with Lanthimos had already passed through *The Favourite* and the silent black-and-white short *Bleat* (2022), whose monochrome silence anticipates the opening section of *Poor Things*.

8.2 *McNamara's idiom and the grammar of subordination*

Tony McNamara's writing for *The Favourite* and for the television series *The Great* (2020–2023), which presented Catherine the Great as an Enlightenment reader who seizes power from a buffoonish husband,

established an idiom of anachronistic profanity and epigrammatic brutality in period dress. *Poor Things* adds a new instrument: Bella's idiolect. Her early speech is paratactic, literal, and inventive, built from short declaratives, unexpected coinages, and an indifference to register that makes every euphemism visible by refusing it. As she develops, subordinate clauses enter her speech; her sentences acquire concession, condition, and irony. The grammar of subordination arrives at precisely the moment the subject learns to refuse subordination. Her syntax matures as her independence does, and the film records her *Bildung* as a philological event.

8.3 *Color, lens, set*

The film opens its account of Bella's life in black and white and turns to color with her departure from London. Thereafter color belongs to her experience; the London of her absence, in which Godwin and Max make Felicity, remains largely monochrome. The precedent is *The Wizard of Oz* (1939), whose sepia Kansas gives way to Technicolor Oz, and the production designer has said that she imagined the film's Lisbon as a dusty, Oz-like place (Flew 2023). But *The Wizard of Oz* returns its heroine to sepia and to the lesson that there is no place like home. *Poor Things* refuses the return. When Bella comes home, home is in color. The world is permanently altered by her perception of it, and the chromatic regime makes the argument of this thesis visible: the subject does not return to the house she left; she remakes it.

Robbie Ryan's cinematography, which had already used extreme wide-angle lenses in *The Favourite*, deploys ultra-wide and fisheye optics and circular vignettes that frame the image as if seen through a lens, a peephole, or a microscope. The sets were designed for these lenses. Godwin's house, built, like the film's other worlds, on the two largest soundstages in Hungary, avoided straight lines because the wide lens warps them, and so its ceilings and doorways curve; its walls are panelled in brain-like patterns, ears are sculpted into its ceiling, organs float in formaldehyde, and its palette is fleshy pink (Flew 2023). The ship's ocean and sunset were projected on a curved LED screen wrapped around the hull; Lisbon was built without blue, its famous tiles re-imagined in red; Paris was designed in the lilac-grey of snow, its trees red like lungs or veins, its brothel crowned with phallic windows and furnished with a light-up floor that nods to Kubrick (Flew 2023). Every world in the film is a body turned inside out.

The film's artifice is avowed rather than concealed. Its lineage runs through Méliès's painted cosmos, Powell and Pressburger's *The Tales of*

Hoffmann (1951), whose Olympia dances in a world of painted flats, and Fellini's *Casanova* (1976), in which the libertine dances with and makes love to a mechanical doll. Wedderburn is a Casanova who has found a doll that will not be wound. Holly Waddington's costumes complete the design: sleeves that swell, garments that look unfinished, a wardrobe that seems to grow with its wearer. The clothes are a developmental record worn on the body.

8.4 *The gaze, and whose*

Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) argued that classical cinema organizes looking around a male spectator, constructing woman as image, defined by her "to-be-looked-at-ness," and offering her body to voyeuristic and fetishistic pleasure. The most sustained criticism of *Poor Things* has applied Mulvey's argument to its many scenes of nudity and sex. The critique cannot be dismissed by appeal to the film's intentions, but three formal facts complicate it.

First, the optics mark the act of looking. The fisheye distortions and circular vignettes frame many shots as seen through an aperture, so that the image announces itself as a view rather than presenting itself as the world. This is a Brechtian estrangement of the voyeur's keyhole: the peephole is made visible. Second, Stone's performance de-eroticizes the sexual scenes through comic timing, athletic matter-of-factness, and the absence of the conventional signs of erotic display; Bella has sex as she eats, with curiosity and appetite, not as she is looked at. Third, Stone was a producer of the film, and has defended its frankness as fidelity to a character who has no shame to perform; her producer's credit and her defense of these scenes were widely reported on the film's release. The debate over a "female gaze," articulated by Joey Soloway in a lecture of 2016 and systematized by Iris Brey, who defined it as a gaze that makes the spectator share the female character's experience rather than look at her body, offers a criterion the film partly meets (Soloway 2016; Brey 2020).

I propose, however, that the film's gaze is best described as neither male nor female but clinical. It is the gaze of the case history, the gaze of Max's notebook and Godwin's observation, which Foucault traced to the birth of the clinic and its *regard médical*, the trained eye that reads the truth of the body on its surface (Foucault 1963). The film begins with that gaze trained on Bella. It ends with Bella holding it. In the final sequences she reads, observes, diagnoses, and operates. The clinical gaze changes hands; it does not disappear. This is the film's honesty, since it does not pretend to dissolve the asymmetry of looking, and its limit, since the gaze it bequeaths to its heroine remains a gaze of power over bodies.

8.5 *Suture and scar*

Film theory borrowed its most influential metaphor from surgery. Jacques-Alain Miller's "La suture" (1966) described the relation of the subject to the chain of signifiers that represents it; Jean-Pierre Oudart transposed the concept to cinema, arguing that the shot/reverse-shot figure stitches the spectator into the fiction by answering the question of who is looking (Oudart 1969); Daniel Dayan called the system the "tutor-code" of classical cinema (Dayan 1974); and Kaja Silverman synthesized the theory's account of how the spectator is sewn into the film's discourse (Silverman 1983). Classical continuity hides its sutures. It cuts constantly while producing the illusion of seamless space.

Poor Things exposes them. Its abrupt changes of stock and lens, its vignetted apertures, its painted skies and projected seas, and its avowedly constructed cities show the joins. Godwin's face, scarred by the surgical experiments his father performed on him as a child, is the film's emblem of its own form: a body that displays how it was assembled. I call this an aesthetics of the visible scar. It is the formal counterpart of the ethical principle that Chapter Nine will formulate: an operation that does not conceal that it has operated.

Walter Benjamin anticipated the analogy between cinema and surgery in his essay on the work of art in the age of technical reproducibility. Magician and surgeon, he wrote, stand to each other as painter and cameraman: the magician heals by laying on hands and keeps his distance from the patient, while the surgeon cuts into the patient's body; the painter maintains a natural distance from the given, while the cameraman penetrates deep into its *Gewebe*, a word that means both web and tissue (Benjamin 1935–36). *Poor Things* literalizes Benjamin's analogy twice. It is a film about surgery whose camera behaves surgically, and its heroine ascends, in the course of the story, to the position of the camera: the operating eye and hand. Benjamin's surgeon is, by this route, a woman. The casting supplies a final irony: the creator whose position she inherits is played by an actor who had played Christ for Scorsese in *The Last Temptation of Christ* (1988), and whose performance here, by his own account, drew on videos of Alasdair Gray (McIlroy 2024). The son of God, the author of the book, and the maker of the creature converge in one scarred face, and the creature takes his instruments.

8.6 *Sound and the moving body*

Jerskin Fendrix's score, detuned and dissonant, built from wavering strings, wheezing organ, and fragments that seem to be learning to become melodies, is the sonic analogue of the film's developmental time. The fado sung in Lisbon by the Portuguese singer Carminho introduces into this soundworld the first fully formed music Bella hears, and the scene marks her first aesthetic emotion. Stone's physical performance belongs to the tradition of silent comedy, from the deadpan of Buster Keaton to the jointed motion of the automaton, and to Bergson's theory of the comic, analyzed in Chapter Four. The film's sounds and movements share a principle: they begin mechanical and become supple, and the suppleness is the sign of a subject.

8.7 *A cinema of the made woman*

The film enters a cinematic lineage as long as the literary one. James Whale's *Bride of Frankenstein* (1935) cast Elsa Lanchester both as Mary Shelley, in a prologue, and as the Bride, whose single gesture upon animation is to hiss and scream at the creature to whom she has been promised. The Bride's refusal, which lasts seconds and ends in her destruction, is cinema's first Frankenstein Clause. Fritz Lang's *Metropolis* (1927) displayed the false Maria, a machine in a woman's likeness, as a dancer whose body incites the crowd, an image framed by the Whore of Babylon. Bryan Forbes's *The Stepford Wives* (1975) reversed the clause: women who might refuse are replaced by compliant machines. Jonathan Glazer's *Under the Skin* (2013) followed an alien in a woman's body as she learned embodiment, tasted cake and spat it out, studied her body in a mirror, and was burned by a man in a forest; it is the exact inverse of *Poor Things*, whose heroine tastes custard tarts with rapture and survives the men. Alex Garland's *Ex Machina* (2014) staged the clause as a thriller, in which the made woman kills her maker, imprisons her would-be rescuer, and walks into the world.

Greta Gerwig's *Barbie*, released in the same year as *Poor Things*, offers the closest contemporary comparison. A doll leaves her world for the human one, discovers patriarchy, is released into humanity by the blessing of her female creator, and ends at a gynecologist's office. Barbie is a doll seeking a body; Bella is a body seeking a mind. Barbie's creator is a woman who gives permission; Bella's is a man who struggles to give it. Barbie's feminism is articulated in a monologue; Bella's is enacted in a practice. And among all these films, *Poor Things* is the only one in which the made

woman becomes the maker. Lang's Maria is burned, Whale's Bride is destroyed, Glazer's alien is killed, Garland's Ava escapes, and Gerwig's Barbie is born. Bella operates.

IX

Chirurgical Humanism

The Graft, the Garden, and the Goat

THE PRECEDING CHAPTERS HAVE assembled the materials of an argument. Bella refuses the anterior compact; she is formed as an experimental subject; her eros becomes an instrument of inquiry; she passes through the heterotopias of exchange; she recovers and refuses her mother; the novel gives her a pen and the film a scalpel. This chapter assembles these materials into the theory announced in the Introduction. It proceeds from the graft, through the hand, to Pico's two vectors, the goat, and the garden; it then confronts the strongest objection to the theory; it states the theory in five theses; and it closes with a Roman fable that the work, without citing, reenacts.

9.1 *The graft and the bastard flower*

In the sheep-shearing scene of *The Winter's Tale*, Perdita declines to grow streaked gillyflowers, which some call "nature's bastards," because their variegation is the product of human art. Polixenes answers her with the period's most compact philosophy of technique. We marry a gentler scion to the wildest stock, he says, and make the baser bark conceive by a nobler bud: "this is an art / Which does mend nature, change it rather, but / The art itself is nature" (*The Winter's Tale* IV.iv). Godwin's house is a garden of nature's bastards: goose-dogs, pig-hens, and a woman composed of a mother's body and a daughter's brain. Donna Haraway's observation that illegitimate offspring are often unfaithful to their origins, since their fathers are, after all, inessential, describes their politics (Haraway 1985). The work sides with Polixenes. Its art mends nature by changing it, and the art is itself nature.

The philosophical history of the human has offered two dominant models. The first is the organism. Wilhelm von Humboldt's ideal of *Bildung*, the self-cultivation of a being toward the fullest development of its powers, gave Mill the epigraph of *On Liberty*, and Mill drew the conclusion in a famous image: human nature "is not a machine to be built after a model," but "a tree, which requires to grow and develop itself on all sides" (Mill 1859, ch. 3). The second is the machine, from Descartes's automata to La Mettrie's *L'Homme machine* (1747). *Poor Things* contains both models and exceeds them. Godwin is a man-machine: his maimed digestion requires an apparatus, and the bubbles that rise from his mouth after meals are the exhaust of a body run partly by engineering. Bella is grown, like Mill's tree, but she was not planted; she was grafted.

The graft is the third model. A grafted being is composed of heterogeneous materials joined by an operative hand, and its identity is located neither in the stock nor in the scion but in the union between them, the scar where they have grown together. Chapter Seven recalled that

"graft" descends from the Greek word for a stylus and that Derrida held writing and grafting to be the same operation. The human as graft is the human as a kind of writing: composed, cited, joined, and legible at its seams.

9.2 *From manus to cheir*

The philology of the hand can now be gathered. Roman law held women in the *manus* of husbands and the *tutela* of guardians, and released sons by an *emancipatio* grounded in a fiction of triple sale. Germanic law held women in the *mundium* and denied them *selbmundia*, and Kant's *Vormund* and *Unmündigkeit* preserve the institution in the vocabulary of enlightenment. English law covered the married woman under her husband's wing. Every station of this history defines a woman's subordination as being held in another's hand. *Emancipation*, accordingly, has been imagined as release: *e manu*, out of the hand.

Poor Things proposes a different terminus. Bella is not released from the hand into a condition of handlessness. She takes the hand. Her trajectory runs from being handled, by guardians, lovers, clients, and a husband, to handling: books, ideas, money, and finally instruments. The last of these is the scalpel, and surgery, *cheirourgia*, is hand-work. Emancipation completes itself not as *e manu capere*, to take out of the hand, but as *manu capere*, to take in hand.

The philosophical stakes of this terminus are sharpened by a debate on the hand. In *Was heißt Denken?* (1954), Heidegger claimed that only a being that can speak, and therefore think, can have hands; the ape has grasping organs, but no hand. Derrida's "Geschlecht II: Heidegger's Hand" (1985) read this claim as the last stronghold of a humanism that defines the human by a privilege denied to animals, and his title, *Geschlecht*, meaning sex, genus, lineage, and race at once, bound the question of the hand to the question of sexual difference. The film's last scene redistributes hands across exactly that difference. Bella acquires the operative hand. Blessington, a body that still has hands, has lost the hand in Heidegger's sense: he moves on all fours and grazes. The humanist criterion is enacted and transferred in a single tableau.

9.3 *Pico's two vectors*

Pico's God told Adam that he could degenerate into the lower forms of life, which are brutes, or be reborn by his own decision into the higher, which are divine. The film's ending stages both vectors at once, in two bodies. Bella regenerates into the position the work had reserved for its God: she

occupies his theater, holds his instruments, and makes a creature. Blessington degenerates into the brute. Pico's anthropology, which assigned both possibilities to every human being, is distributed by the film as a moral judgment. The man who treated a woman as an animal is made one; the woman whom men treated as a creature becomes a creator.

The transformation has precedents, and the film revises each. Circe turned Odysseus's men into swine (*Odyssey* X), and her art has been read ever since as a female power over male bestiality. In Apuleius's *Metamorphoses*, Lucius is turned into an ass by his own curiosity about magic and is restored to human form by Isis when he eats the roses carried in her procession; his story ends in redemption. Blessington is not redeemed; he eats grass, not roses. In Wells's *The Island of Doctor Moreau* (1896), a vivisector carves animals into parodies of men and binds them with a Law whose first article reads "Not to go on all-Fours; that is the Law. Are we not Men?" Bella reverses Moreau's direction, carving a man into an animal, and abolishes his Law: her goat may go on all fours. Lanthimos's own *The Lobster*, as Chapter Eight observed, punished the refusal of coupledom by transformation into an animal. *Poor Things* reserves the punishment for the enforcer.

9.4 *The goat*

The choice of animal is overdetermined. In Leviticus, two goats are taken on the Day of Atonement; one is sacrificed, and the other, the goat for Azazel, is sent into the wilderness bearing the iniquities of the community (Leviticus 16). Northrop Frye made the *pharmakos*, the scapegoat, a structural figure of both tragedy and comedy, the character whose expulsion purges the society the plot reconstitutes (Frye 1957). René Girard theorized the mechanism: a community in mimetic crisis, its members rivals for the same objects, recovers its unity by turning its violence on a single surrogate victim (Girard 1972). The male rivals of *Poor Things*, Max, Wedderburn, and Blessington, are in mimetic crisis over Bella, and the crisis resolves when its most violent member is turned, literally, into a goat. Derrida's "La pharmacie de Platon" traced the chain that joins *pharmakon*, remedy and poison, to *pharmakos*, the scapegoat (Derrida 1972). In the final tableau the chain is embodied: Bella, the physician, is the *pharmakon*; Blessington is the *pharmakos*.

The goat carries a second iconography. Medieval and Renaissance imagery frequently assigned the goat to Luxuria, the personification of lust. Blessington, who intended to excise his wife's pleasure, becomes the emblem of the vice he wished to cut out of her. And the goat was the presiding animal of the misogynist fantasy of the witches' sabbath. Dürer

engraved a witch riding backward on a goat (c. 1500); Goya's *El aquelarre* (1797–98) shows a great he-goat enthroned among women who offer it infants. Silvia Federici read the European witch-hunts, in which church and secular courts executed tens of thousands of people, most of them women, as a war on women's bodies, their reproductive autonomy, and their healing knowledge (Federici 2004). The final garden of *Poor Things* is a sabbath without Satan. The he-goat, once the fantasized master of women's gatherings, grazes as their pet among a woman training in surgery, her lover Toinette, Max, her sister-creature Felicity, and Mrs Prim. The actress who played the brothel's madam had played all three of Macbeth's witches two years before (Chapter Five); the film's casting keeps the old female powers in view.

The tableau is also, in Bakhtin's terms, a carnival decrowning. Carnival crowns a mock king and then uncrowns him, stripping the regalia from the body and returning it to the earth (Bakhtin 1965). The general's decrowning is total: his rank, his pistol, his name, and his mind are stripped away, and his body is returned, quite literally, to grazing on the earth. And it completes the inversion of the *Oresteia* traced in Chapter Six. Aeschylus housed the Furies beneath Athens; Lanthimos and McNamara house the patriarch in a garden.

9.5 *The last garden*

The film ends in a garden, and the garden condenses the history of humanist and religious gardens. It is Eden after a fall that never happened, a garden in which the apple brought knowledge without shame (Genesis 2–3). It revokes the *hortus conclusus* of the Song of Songs, the "garden inclosed" that became the Marian figure of virginity (Song of Songs 4:12), by opening the garden to a woman of many partners. It recalls Rabelais's Abbey of Thélème, whose only rule was "Fay ce que vouldras," do what you will, and whose men and women lived freely together (Rabelais 1534), and Christine de Pizan's *Cité des dames* (1405), built by Reason, Rectitude, and Justice as a refuge for women from the misogyny of authorities. Its closest precedent is Margaret Cavendish's *The Blazing World* (1666), in which a woman becomes empress of a world of hybrid creatures, bear-men, bird-men, fox-men, and worm-men, organized as learned societies: the first utopia in English in which a woman presides over a garden of chimeras devoted to natural philosophy.

The garden is also Voltaire's. *Candide* ends with its little society of survivors, its optimist still philosophizing and its ruined lovers reconciled to labor, resolving that one must cultivate one's garden (Voltaire 1759). Bella's ship carried a Pangloss and a Martin, and her garden repeats

Candide's resolution with a difference: the cultivation it practices is surgical. It is Mill's tree transplanted into Polixenes's orchard. It is the oldest of Foucault's heterotopias, the garden as a microcosm of the world (Foucault 1984). And it is Haraway's household of made kin, assembled by affinity rather than descent, in accordance with her injunction to make kin rather than babies (Haraway 2016). Except for the tacit and now meaningless biological tie between Bella and the creature grazing on the lawn, nobody in Bella's garden is related to anybody else by blood. It is non-reproductive, multispecies, and chosen. Gray, whose paintings returned throughout his life to the Garden of Eden and to the triumph of death (Glasgow School of Art Archives), would have recognized in it the conjunction of his two subjects: a garden built on a corpse.

The garden belongs, moreover, to the house that Godwin designed as a womb (Flew 2023). Bella inherits the male-built matrix in which she was reanimated and converts it into her own household. Arendt's distinction between the household, the realm of necessity, and the polis, the realm of freedom, is here unsettled. The final household is not a retreat from the world of action into the realm of necessity; it is a household into which action has entered, a refounded *oikos* whose members chose one another and whose mistress chose her vocation.

9.6 *The master's tools*

The strongest objection to this reading was formulated by Audre Lorde in 1979: the master's tools will never dismantle the master's house. They may permit a temporary victory on the master's terms, Lorde argued, but they cannot produce genuine change. *Poor Things* invites the objection with unusual literalness. The scalpel Bella takes up was Godwin's, and Godwin's father had used one on Godwin, performing surgical experiments on his own child; the genealogy of the instrument runs from a father who abused his son in the name of science, to a son who experimented on a drowned woman's body and on animals, to the woman who now operates on a man without his consent. The house in which she lives is the master's house, in the most literal sense, inherited. Her final act exercises over another body the sovereignty that was exercised over hers.

The objection has a second, older form. Wollstonecraft wrote that she did not wish women "to have power over men; but over themselves" (Wollstonecraft 1792, ch. 4). The goat ending gives Bella power over a man, and of the most absolute kind. What she does must be named plainly. While Blessington lies unconscious, she removes his brain and replaces it with a goat's, without his consent and without any trial. By the criterion of personal identity defended in Chapter Three, which Bella herself relied on

against his claim, the operation ends Blessington as a person: his memory, character, and will are destroyed, and only his body is kept alive. Whether the film invites us to read it as rescue, revenge, or protection, it is in moral substance the killing of a person by a private individual acting on her own authority. Benjamin's "Zur Kritik der Gewalt" (1921) distinguished mythic violence, which founds and preserves law, from divine violence, which destroys law and expiates; Bella's operation fits neither category cleanly. It destroys the coverture claim, but it is bloody, sovereign, and administered by one person on another's body. And Benjamin's later dictum, that there is no document of culture which is not at the same time a document of barbarism (Benjamin 1940, VII), applies to the final tableau with full force.

I do not think the work answers this objection, and I do not think it tries to. What it does is refuse to hide it. The goat is visibly there in the last scene, on all fours on the lawn, as the price of the garden's peace. Benjamin's concept of the dialectical image, "dialectics at a standstill," names a constellation in which the contradictions of a historical moment become legible in a single image without being resolved (Benjamin 1982). The final tableau is such an image: emancipation and domination, care and violence, the woman with the book and the man with the goat's brain, appear in one frame. The comedy of the ending, which follows Frye's pattern of a new society formed around the young by the expulsion of the blocking figure, is what makes the violence bearable. The visibility of the goat is what keeps the violence from being forgotten. The work's ethics, in other words, coincides with its aesthetics of the visible scar. It operates, and it shows that it has operated.

9.7 *Five theses on chirurgical humanism*

The theory can now be stated in five theses.

The first thesis holds that the human is a graft rather than an organism or a machine. It is composed of heterogeneous materials, bodily, linguistic, legal, and historical, joined by operations it did not perform, and its identity is located in the scar where those materials have grown together. Against Mill's tree and La Mettrie's machine, chirurgical humanism places Polixenes's scion.

The second thesis holds that human dignity resides in operative capacity: in the cultivated power of the hand to cut, join, and reassemble the given, including one's own given. It does not reside in a fixed essence, as natural law held; nor in the self-legislation of a rational will, as Kant held; nor merely in the fact of social construction, which describes the condition of every subject without specifying what any subject can do with

it. Emancipation completes itself as the appropriation of the hand: from *manus* to *cheir*.

The third thesis holds that every subject is born into anterior compacts, and that freedom begins with the Frankenstein Clause, the reasoned refusal of compacts made before one's creation. But refusal is not yet freedom. It must pass into operation, into repair and rejoining, to become a capacity rather than a negation.

The fourth thesis holds that the operative hand inherits the violence of the hand it replaces. The scalpel has a genealogy, and the master's tools carry the master's habits. Chirurgical humanism therefore requires a discipline of the visible scar, in ethics as in form: it must operate without concealing that it operates, and it must leave the costs of its operations on view, as the film leaves its goat on the lawn.

The fifth thesis holds that the proper end of chirurgical humanism is neither the polis of citizens nor the enclosed garden of virginity, but the graft-garden: a non-reproductive community of made kin, human and nonhuman, in which care replaces possession. The Latin *cura*, from which "cure" descends, means care before it means treatment; the surgeon's cure is a form of care. The hand that cures replaces the hand that owns.

9.8 *Cura*

The Roman mythographer Hyginus preserved a fable that Heidegger placed at the center of *Sein und Zeit* (1927, §42), and that *Poor Things* reenacts without naming. *Cura cum quendam fluvium transiret*: Care, a goddess, was crossing a river when she saw some clay, and, taking it up thoughtfully, she began to shape a human being. Jupiter gave the figure spirit. Then the claimants quarreled over its name: Jupiter wanted it named after himself, Earth wanted it named after herself, since she had furnished its body. Saturn, who is Time, judged the case. At death, Jupiter would receive the spirit and Earth the body; but because Care had first shaped it, Care should hold it as long as it lived. And it would be called *homo*, because it was made from *humus*, the earth (Hyginus, *Fabulae* 220).

Every element of the fable is present in *Poor Things*. A human is shaped from material taken from a river. Spirit is breathed into it. Rival claimants quarrel over its name and its ownership, one appealing to the body he once possessed, as Earth did, and another to the life he gave it. The quarrel is settled by time, which is to say by Bella's development, which outruns every claim. And the being belongs, while it lives, to Care. The fable distinguishes two kinds of holding. The *manus* of the husband holds by title and seeks to hold forever; the hand of *Cura* holds by making and caring, and holds only as long as its creature lives. The verb Saturn uses is

teneat, let her hold. Chirurgical humanism is a theory of the second kind of holding.

The film's closing tableau places Bella in the garden with a book, a surgeon who reads. The two hands of the bimanual feminism described in Chapter Seven, the scriptorial and the surgical, Victoria's pen and Bella's scalpel, are joined in her at last. She is the woman who writes and the woman who cuts, and the scar between those capacities is her identity.

Conclusion

In the Early Days of a Better Body

Poor Things, in both its bodies, has been read as a feminist *Frankenstein*, a picaresque *Bildungsroman*, a Menippean satire, and a male fantasy of female liberation. This thesis has argued that each reading captures a surface of the work while missing its governing structure. That structure has three terms. Its problem is the *anterior compact*, the ensemble of prior bindings, legal, philosophical, sexual, and narrative, into which a female subject is born. Its act is the *Frankenstein Clause*, the reasoned refusal of compacts made before one's creation, which Victor Frankenstein dreaded and Bella Baxter performs. Its instrument is the hand, which the European vocabulary of women's subordination has always placed at the center, and which the work transfers, at its end, into the woman's possession.

Contributions

The argument has made five contributions. First, it has proposed a hermeneutic. The anterior compact unifies under one concept forms of binding usually studied apart: Roman *manus* and *tutela*, the Germanic *mundium*, English coverture, Kant's guardianship, Pateman's sexual contract, and the canonical compact by which the nineteenth-century novel contracted its sexual heroines to die. The Frankenstein Clause names both the refusal of such compacts and the dread the refusal inspires.

Second, it has reconstructed a philology of the hand: from *manus* and *emancipatio*, whose origin is a fiction of triple sale, through *munt*, *selbmundia*, *Vormund*, and *Unmündigkeit*, to *cheirourgia*; from *graft*, which descends from the word for a stylus, to the *teneat* of Hyginus's fable, in which Care holds the human she made only as long as it lives. On this philology rests the claim that emancipation, in this work, completes itself not as release from the hand but as the taking of the hand.

Third, it has established a series of intertextual and historical identifications that previous criticism has not drawn together. They include the family romance of Wollstonecraft, Godwin, and the Shelleys, encoded in the name Godwin Bysshe Baxter and in Victoria's leap from a London bridge; the Orkney laboratory in which Victor destroyed the female creature Gray revived in Scotland; Poe's "Morella" as the work's miniature; Kant's go-cart and domestic animals, literalized in Godwin's house; the triple sale of *emancipatio*, re-enacted in Bella's three transfers; Truffaut's irises and Lanthimos's own *Dogtooth* and Tsangari's *Attenberg* as formal ancestors; Foucault's catalogue of heterotopias as the work's itinerary; Marx's speaking commodity and Irigaray's commodities that refuse the market; Lear's superflux and Wilde's critique of charity; the inverted *Oresteia* and the transfigured *Winter's Tale*; Hogg's *Justified Sinner*

and Bakhtin's menippea as the novel's generic charter; and the fable of Cura as the work's unacknowledged myth of origin.

Fourth, it has given an account of the adaptation as a graft governed by a principle of exteriorization. The film converts the novel's internal contradictions into external conflicts: the wife's internalized wish for her own mutilation becomes the husband's plan; the epistemic dispute between two men over a woman's letter becomes a plot in which men compete for her body; and the novel's *transcendent* refutation, in which a woman's pen denies the men's fantasy from outside, becomes the film's *immanent* refutation, in which a woman's scalpel ends the men's power from within the fantasy. Gray's book culminates in a letter and Lanthimos's film in a goat, and the two together constitute a bimanual feminism.

Fifth, it has formulated a theory, chirurgical humanism, in five theses: the human as graft rather than organism or machine; dignity as operative capacity rather than essence, will, or construction; freedom as the passage from refusal to operation; the discipline of the visible scar as the ethical and formal condition of any operation; and the graft-garden of made kin, governed by care rather than possession, as the end the theory proposes.

Limits

The argument has limits, and several of them are the work's own. The critique of the film's male authorship and of its images of a woman whose mind is depicted as young has been reframed, not refuted; the reframing identifies the guardian's anxiety that the film transmits to its spectator, but it cannot guarantee that the anxiety is not also enjoyed. The film's ending, in which its heroine destroys a man's mind on her own authority, is offered as comedy; this thesis has read it as a dialectical image, but the act remains what it is. The colonized poor of Alexandria remain silent, and the film's humanism retains the vantage of the balcony. The clinical gaze that the film transfers to Bella remains a gaze of power over bodies. And the theory of chirurgical humanism carries a danger that its fourth thesis names but cannot abolish. The hand is not virtuous in itself. Isaac Baker Brown held a scalpel too, and so would whatever surgeon Blessington engaged to carry out his plan. A humanism of operative capacity is a humanism of power, and it can be redeemed only by the discipline of visibility, by an operation that shows, at every point, that it has operated and what it has cost.

Implications

The implications reach beyond the work. For feminist theory, *Poor Things* suggests a way past the long opposition between essence and construction: the decisive question is neither what a woman is by nature nor how she was made by society, but what she can do with what she has been given, including her own construction. It suggests, likewise, a way past the binary of the sex wars, by relocating the danger of sexuality from sex itself to ownership. For the history of humanism, it offers a humanism after posthumanism, one that retains the hand as the site of dignity while distributing it across sexual difference and placing it under the discipline of care. For adaptation studies, it supports a model of adaptation as grafting rather than translation or fidelity, a model in which the scar between source and adaptation is the locus of meaning. For film theory, it proposes the visible scar as the formal counterpart of an ethics, an alternative both to classical suture and to the pure deconstruction of the image.

Coda: Gray's body

Alasdair Gray's paintings, according to the archive of the school where he trained, returned throughout his life to two subjects, the Garden of Eden and the triumph of death; and when he died in 2019, he left his body to science (Glasgow School of Art Archives). The maker of Godwin Baxter, whose face and voice Willem Dafoe studied in order to play the creator, ended by entrusting his own body to the anatomists' hands (McIlroy 2024). The author of the anatomy became its material. There is no more exact emblem of the work's thesis: the maker becomes the made, the body becomes the occasion of knowledge, and the operation is performed in the open.

Gray borrowed from Dennis Lee the injunction to work as though one lived in the early days of a better nation, and the line now stands on the wall of the parliament he spent his life demanding. *Poor Things* proposes a corollary for the subject rather than the state: to work as though one lived in the early days of a better body. Such a body knows that it is grafted. It shows its scars. It refuses the compacts that were made before its creation. And it is held, as long as it lives, by care.

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Keywords

Poor Things; Alasdair Gray; Yorgos Lanthimos; Tony McNamara; adaptation studies; Frankenstein Clause; anterior compact; chirurgical humanism; graft; emancipation; *Unmündigkeit*; *mundium*; coverture; sexual contract; Mary Shelley; Mary Wollstonecraft; William Godwin; Immanuel Kant; Pico della Mirandola; John Stuart Mill; Carole Pateman; Luce Irigaray; Michel Foucault; heterotopia; *scientia sexualis*; *ars erotica*; Victorian sexuality; clitoridectomy; prostitution; commodity fetishism; Marxist feminism; matricide; *Oresteia*; drowned heroine; Elisabeth Bronfen; Menippean satire; historiographic metafiction; Scottish literature; the fantastic; suture theory; male gaze; clinical gaze; Walter Benjamin; Audre Lorde; Donna Haraway; posthumanism; natality; feminist humanism.